

Making Arrangement

Katagiri Roshi's Teachings on *Fukanzazengi*,
Zen Master Dōgen's *Universal Recommendation for Zazen*

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Introduction

Zen Master Dōgen's *Fukanzazengi* ("Universal Recommendation for Zazen") is probably the most fundamental text of Sōtō Zen Buddhism. Composed by Eihei Dōgen in 13th century Japan, written in Classical Chinese, it explains both the *how* and the *why* of Zen meditation. Traditionally this short text is recited every evening during *sesshin* (Zen meditation retreat), but it has meaning for practitioners in all areas of life – hence "*Universal Recommendation*."

Dainin Katagiri Roshi, the founder of Sōtō Zen in Minnesota, worked for decades to bring Dōgen Zenji's teachings to English-speaking Americans, giving hundreds of dharma talks at Minnesota Zen Meditation Center. In this document, I go through *Fukanzazengi* line-by-line and attempt to bring together Katagiri Roshi's teachings on each part of the text, drawn from many of his different talks over the years from 1979 to 1989.

This is a work in progress. I will be updating this document as I continue to transcribe talks and find additional references, and perhaps some day we might even have access to additional talks that we don't have access to today. Nevertheless, after six or so years of slow but steady work on transcribing Katagiri Roshi's talks, there is a solid basis to begin this project.

All of the transcripts of Katagiri Roshi's talks that I draw from (and more; with the exception of those on *The Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness*) are on the Katagiri Transcripts website. If you are viewing this document as a PDF, you should be able to follow the links to get to the complete transcripts. Katagiri Roshi's dharma talks are being used with permission of Minnesota Zen Meditation Center.

The purpose of the Katagiri Transcripts project is to help convey the teachings of Katagiri Roshi and Eihei Dōgen to the next generation. I present this work in the spirit of ongoing investigation and practice. Any errors in understanding here are my own.

About the English Translations of *Fukanzazengi*

[SZ] indicates the Sōtōshū translation of *Fukanzazengi*. This translation is commonly used in English-speaking Zen centers.

[EB] indicates text from the translation of *Fukanzazengi* by Norman Waddell and Masao Abe in *The Eastern Buddhist* magazine, Vol. 6, No. 2 (October, 1973), pp. 115-128. This is the translation that Katagiri Roshi himself was using in the 1970s.

[KR] indicates a translation which appears to be by Katagiri Roshi himself.

Manuscript

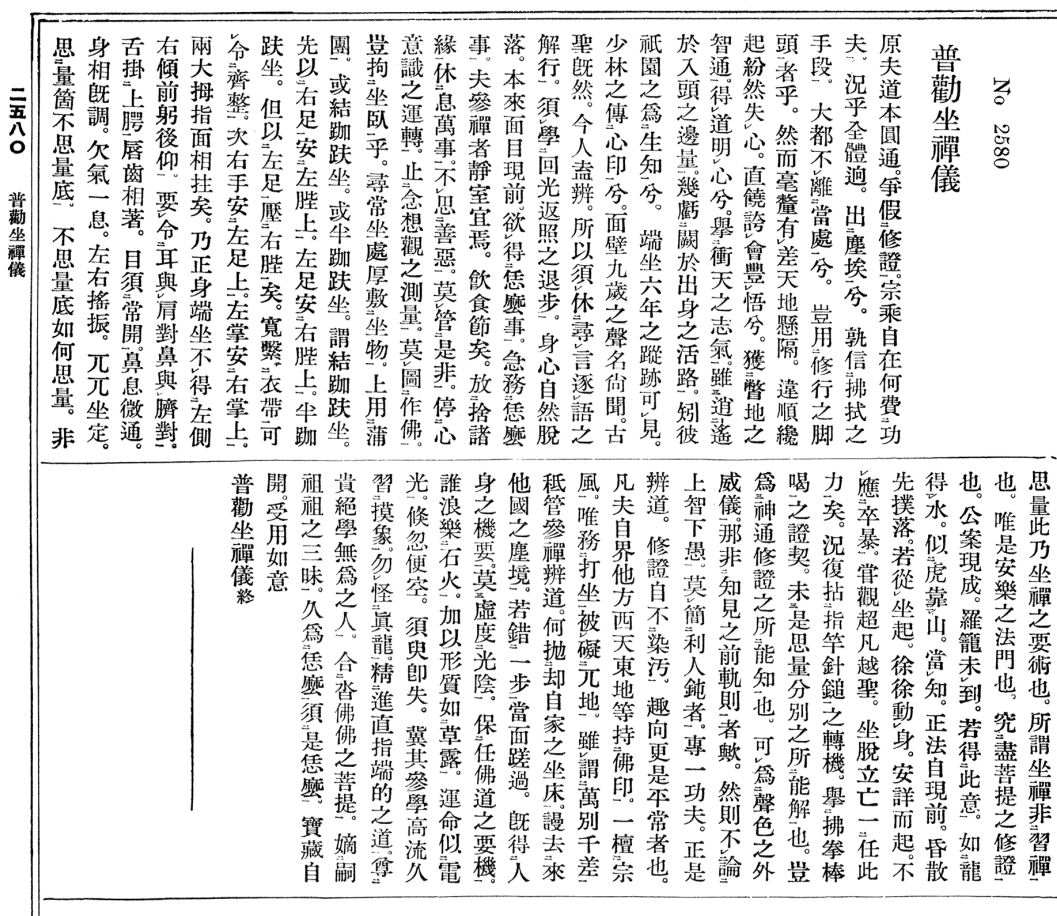


Figure 1: The *Rufu-bon* ("Popular Version") of *Fukanzazengi*. The text is in Classical Chinese; the characters are read in vertical lines from right to left, with two blocks of text, top and bottom. Source: [The Taishō Tripitaka](#), SAT Daizōkyō Text Database, Volume 82, Text 2580. Via [dharmawanderer.wordpress.com](#).

Translation

Fukan Zazengi (Universally Recommended Instructions for Zazen)

The way is originally perfect and all-pervading. How could it be contingent on practice and realization? The true vehicle is self-sufficient. What need is there for special effort? Indeed, the whole body is free from dust. Who could believe in a means to brush it clean? It is never apart from this very place; what is the use of traveling around to practice?

And yet, if there is a hairsbreadth deviation, it is like the gap between heaven and earth. If the least like or dislike arises, the mind is lost in confusion. Suppose you are confident in your understanding and rich in enlightenment, gaining the wisdom that knows at a glance, attaining the Way and clarifying the mind, arousing an aspiration to reach for the heavens. You are playing in the entranceway, but you are still short of the vital path of emancipation.

Consider the Buddha: although he was wise at birth, the traces of his six years of upright sitting can yet be seen. As for Bodhidharma, although he had received the mind-seal, his nine years of facing a wall is celebrated still. If even the ancient sages were like this, how can we today dispense with wholehearted practice?

Therefore, put aside the intellectual practice of investigating words and chasing phrases, and learn to take the backward step that turns the light and shines it inward. Body and mind of themselves will drop away, and your original face will manifest. If you want to realize such, get to work on such right now.

For practicing Zen, a quiet room is suitable. Eat and drink moderately. Put aside all involvements and suspend all affairs. Do not think “good” or “bad.” Do not judge true or false. Give up the operations of mind, intellect, and consciousness; stop measuring with thoughts, ideas, and views. Have no designs on becoming a buddha. How could that be limited to sitting or lying down?

At your sitting place, spread out a thick mat and put a cushion on it. Sit either in the full-lotus or half-lotus position. In the full-lotus position, first place your right foot on your left thigh, then your left foot on your right thigh. In the half-lotus, simply place your left foot on your right thigh. Tie

your robes loosely and arrange them neatly. Then place your right hand on your left leg and your left hand on your right palm, thumb-tips lightly touching. Straighten your body and sit upright, leaning neither left nor right, neither forward nor backward. Align your ears with your shoulders and your nose with your navel. Rest the tip of your tongue against the front of the roof of your mouth, with teeth together and lips shut. Always keep your eyes open, and breathe softly through your nose.

Once you have adjusted your posture, take a breath and exhale fully, rock your body right and left, and settle into steady, immovable sitting. Think of not thinking, “Not thinking –what kind of thinking is that?” Nonthinking. This is the essential art of zazen.

The zazen I speak of is not meditation practice. It is simply the dharma gate of joyful ease, the practice realization of totally culminated enlightenment. It is the koan realized; traps and snares can never reach it. If you grasp the point, you are like a dragon gaining the water, like a tiger taking to the mountains. For you must know that the true dharma appears of itself, so that from the start dullness and distraction are struck aside.

When you arise from sitting, move slowly and quietly, calmly and deliberately. Do not rise suddenly or abruptly. In surveying the past, we find that transcendence of both mundane and sacred, and dying while either sitting or standing, have all depended entirely on the power of zazen.

In addition, triggering awakening with a finger, a banner, a needle, or a mallet, and effecting realization with a whisk, a fist, a staff, or a shout –these cannot be understood by discriminative thinking; much less can they be known through the practice of supernatural power. They must represent conduct beyond seeing and hearing. Are they not a standard prior to knowledge and views?

This being the case, intelligence or lack of it is not an issue; make no distinction between the dull and the sharp-witted. If you concentrate your effort single-mindedly, that in itself is wholeheartedly engaging the way. Practice-realization is naturally undefiled. Going forward is, after all, an everyday affair.

In general, in our world and others, in both India and China, all equally hold the buddha-seal. While each lineage expresses its own style, they are all simply devoted to sitting, totally blocked in resolute stability. Although they say that there are ten thousand distinctions and a thousand varia-

tions, they just wholeheartedly engage the way in zazen. Why leave behind the seat in your own home to wander in vain through the dusty realms of other lands? If you make one misstep, you stumble past what is directly in front of you.

You have gained the pivotal opportunity of human form. Do not pass your days and nights in vain. You are taking care of the essential activity of the buddha-way. Who would take wasteful delight in the spark from a flintstone? Besides, form and substance are like the dew on the grass, the fortunes of life like a dart of lightning –emptied in an instant, vanished in a flash.

Please, honored followers of Zen, long accustomed to groping for the elephant, do not doubt the true dragon. Devote your energies to the way of direct pointing at the real. Revere the one who has gone beyond learning and is free from effort. Accord with the enlightenment of all the buddhas; succeed to the samadhi of all the ancestors. Continue to live in such a way, and you will be such a person. The treasure store will open of itself, and you may enjoy it freely.

– Source: sotozen.com

Chapter 1: Universal Recommendation for Zazen

Title

普勸坐禪儀
Fukan zazen gi

Universally Recommended Instructions for Zazen [SZ]

Universal Promotion of the Principles of Zazen [EB]

Universal Recommendation for Zazen [KR]

Commentary

Katagiri Roshi explains the term *zazen*:

Zazen [is] Zen meditation: in Japanese *za zen* (坐禪). *Za* (坐) is “sitting.” *Zen* (禪) is *zen*, “tranquility.”

I always use the term *zazen*, because the *zazen* we do is a little different from the meditation that [...] other religions do. That’s why I want to use the original term *zazen*.

In Chinese, etymologically, the *za* [is that] two persons sit in the universe. (*Transcriber’s Note*: The character *za* 坐 depicts two people 人 sitting on the ground or earth 土.) [...] That [indicates that] you have to sit with more than two beings, [and] not only human beings; you cannot sit alone. So you should sit with more than two beings on the earth, in the universe – not in your own egoistic, selfish territory.

[If] you must open yourself and sit in the universe, very naturally you have to sit *with* all sentient beings. That is called *sitting*. And then very naturally [...] *that* sitting is exactly *zen*, tranquility – because all sentient beings around you are exactly sitting with you! So very naturally that is called *zen*: tranquility.

So you, and the universe, earth, all beings, and all circumstances, [...] become sitting with you, together. This is called *zazen*. All we have to do

is to do our best to sit in the universe with all sentient beings. That's *all* we have to do.

– From “Katagiri Roshi's Zazen Instruction” (1981).

This was how Katagiri Roshi introduced *zazen* to a small group of people in 1981. Note that almost the very first thing he talks about is not a technical explanation, nor an individual goal, but that we sit with all beings, and not just human beings.

This point will come up again, frequently. And we'll return to the definition of zen as *tranquility* in Chapter 12: “Surrender to Tranquility.”

Katagiri Roshi says about sitting down in *zazen*:

Anyone can do it. Even if you are not Buddhist, or even if you cannot come [to the Zen Center], you can sit down. [...] This is *shikantaza* (whole-hearted sitting). [...] This is *freedom* – open to *everybody*! No exceptions.

That's why Dōgen Zenji says “Universal Recommendation for Zazen” – *universal* recommendation. It's really *universal*. [It's] not only weeding out (that is, removing all weeds) on your own territory. Anyone can do it. Wherever you may be, you can do it.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 3,” June 11, 1979, at 1:02:07.

What does Katagiri Roshi mean when he says that *zazen* is not only removing all the weeds on our own territory?

By “weeds,” Katagiri Roshi means any mental or physical conditions that we don't like. We can also understand weeds as *karma* – a topic that we will return to – but again, weeds are the kind of karma that we don't like. Katagiri Roshi says:

According to a narrow understanding of human life, first you cut off the root of your weeds, [then] you want to be happy. That's nice... but it is a narrow understanding. Because you cannot completely cut off the weeds. You cannot destroy weeds. Weeds grow any time, anywhere.

So the important point is arrangement of our circumstances: how to use the weeds. Even the weeds are nothing but being, which is helping all sentient beings.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 1” (June 9, 1979) at 56:36.

So zazen is not about eliminating mental or physical states that we don’t like. Nor, in fact, is it about chasing after mental states that we *do* like. Instead, zazen is about arranging our circumstances – our environment, and our body and mind – so that we can sit *with* all sentient beings.

But what do we mean by “all sentient beings”? This is actually a deep question. In brief, as we will see, “all sentient beings” means *everything*. Sitting with all sentient beings means sitting in the midst of everything that we are experiencing. That, in turn, means sitting in the midst of the total dynamic working of the whole universe.

This is what Katagiri Roshi means by “not only on our own territory.” Zazen is not a kind of meditation where we are attempting to cut ourselves off from this world and its difficulties.

Plainly speaking, this is a different understanding than in some varieties of Buddhism. We will explore this topic in more detail as we go on, especially in Chapter 20: “Dullness and Distraction are Struck Aside.”

But because zazen is just sitting down and being present, that means *anyone* can do this practice. In other words, it is *universal*. Here is how Katagiri Roshi sums up the practice of *shikantaza* (wholehearted sitting), which is the kind of zazen we do:

So, *shikantaza* is arrangement of all things, and then sit down. That’s all.

This is really *bodhisattva* practice, to help all sentient beings. If you practice this, your life is really helpful, for you and for others. It is very true. Even though you don’t say [anything], somebody realizes. You have something to tell him or her.

So that is *shikantaza* – the zazen you do, mentioned by Buddha. It’s pretty difficult for us to understand intellectually, because we are getting the use of always analyzing and synthesizing everything in the dualistic world; it’s very difficult to *stop immediately*. That’s why even though you stop for a while, you don’t appreciate that practice. But this practice is [...] the best way.

We can explain how important this kind of [Buddhist] practice is philosophically, psychologically – but it takes time. That is a huge world, the

philosophical background, psychological background. But even though you don't know [it], you can do it – right now, right here. This is a very urgent need; we have to do it. Whoever you are, wherever you may be, you can do it.

For instance, if you are in an office – well still you can do it. If there is no one there, you can sit down in a chair and calm yourself. If you are talking with somebody, you can realize a certain pause, where no words come up. For that time, you can return to yourself, and breathe.

You can do it, okay? Wherever you may go. It's really universal. It's very simple. It's *too* simple to realize. But, this is the best way. Not only for your life in *this* world, but in the next life, in the life after next life, after next next life, continually.

– From “*Fukanzazengi: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 3*” (June 11, 1979) at 1:09:51.

This is a small part of a much longer talk which ties together many ideas in *Fukanzazengi*, including this notion of practicing for lifetime after lifetime, and what it means to arrange our circumstances. We'll return to those points in the following chapters.

But this is the conclusion: you can do it. Whatever your situation, whether you understand it or not, you can do zazen. This is a *universal* way to benefit both yourself and the entire cosmic situation.

Chapter 2: The Way

Paragraph 1 Part 1

原夫道本圓通、

The Way is originally perfect and all-pervading. [SZ]

The Way is basically perfect and all-pervading. [EB]

The origin of the Way is perfect and all-pervading. [KR]

Commentary

According to *Kenzeiki*, a biography of Dōgen Zenji written in the 15th century, Dōgen's deep question, the one driving him to seek out the truth of Buddhism, was something like this: "If, as the sutras teach, all people are endowed with Buddha-nature, why is it that we have to practice to realize that Buddha-nature?"

In the first part of *Fukanzazengi*, which we discuss in Chapters 2 through 8, Dōgen Zenji restates this question and answers it. To understand his answer, we first need to understand what Dōgen means by "the Way."

"The Way" is *tao* or *dao* (道) in Chinese, or in Japanese, *dō*. Dōgen Zenji's name, *Dō-gen* (道元), means "Way Origin."

Katagiri Roshi gave a series of talks on Zen Master Dōgen's *Gakudō-yōjinshū*, "Points To Watch in Studying the Way". *Gakudō* means "study of the Way." He explains the meaning of the character *dō*:

The Way means the universal life beyond conscious or unconscious worlds. This is the Way, where all beings exist in peace and harmony, prior to the germination of any subtle ideas. [...] All sentient beings exist in the realm of the Way; that is called *universal life*. This life is open not only to human beings or living beings, but also inanimate beings: pebbles, water, et cetera.

– From "Principles of Practice, Talk 1: The Purpose of Practice" (March 19, 1986).

By “beyond conscious or unconscious worlds,” Katagiri Roshi means beyond the worlds created by our conscious or unconscious mental processes. Hence, this is “prior to the germination of any subtle ideas.”

So here “the Way” is not a set of guidelines or procedures to follow, but *universal life*. But what is *universal life*? And isn't “the Way” the teachings of the Buddha – the *buddha-dharma* – which we need to follow?

We can say that to study the Way is to follow the teaching of Buddha. But we need to ask, what do we mean by “Buddha”? And also, what do we mean by “the teaching”?

In a typical translation, *Buddha* is understood as the historical Buddha or the religious personage of “the Buddha.” *Dharma* is often understood as “the teaching.” And *sangha* is usually understood as “the community.” But this misses the significance of these terms in Zen. According to Katagiri Roshi, *Buddha* is the universe. *Dharma* is the teaching of the universe. And *sangha* is the community that makes the universe and its teaching alive in their lives.

This is more the sense in which we can say that the Way is the teaching of Buddha that we need to follow.

Taking refuge in the Triple Treasure – *Buddha*, *dharma*, and *sangha* – is fundamental to all branches of Buddhism. In a Zen temple, we do this together at the start of every morning service, at the start of the Full Moon Precepts ceremony, and in many other ceremonies. We also take refuge in the Three Treasures in our daily life, keeping them close to our hearts.

Katagiri Roshi explains the Triple Treasure:

Dōgen Zenji says:

[Through] day and night, be mindful of the Triple Treasure. In your everyday life, be mindful of the Triple Treasure.

Why? What is the reason why we have to do this? Dōgen Zenji says:

We take refuge in the Buddha because he is our great teacher.

Great means completely beyond the human value good or bad. Buddha is *great* beyond human evaluation. The spirit, the essence of the universe,

merit of the universe, and functioning of the universe is completely great, beyond your speculation. When you realize, you become the universe. *You become the universe* means, in other words we say Buddha. Shakyamuni Buddha – Gotama Siddhartha – realized the essence of the universe, the merit or virtue of the universe, [...] and functioning of the universe, then Gotama Siddhartha [became] Buddha.

We take refuge in [the Dharma] because it is good medicine.

Dharma is teaching; [the] teaching is completely beyond human evaluation, beyond the moral sense or ethical sense. The dharma is something coming from the truth, so it's really beneficial to everyone, all sentient beings – just like a rain nurtures all kind of grasses, trees, pebbles, human beings, and the air, everything. That is dharma; that's why dharma is good medicine.

– From “Lay Ordination Lecture 3 of 7: Triple Treasure, Lecture 1” (March 8, 1986) at 14:00.

In a different talk, Katagiri Roshi further explains the word *dharma*:

Dharma is a very technical Buddhist term, and very popular. It's a philosophical term, but it's not philosophical, [it's a] very spiritual term. So it's a very complicated term. *At the least*, it has three meanings. If you use *dharma*, it is *the principle of existence*. And second, it is *phenomena*: all phenomena, visible and invisible. And also [it is] *teaching*. *Dharma* has at least those three meanings: *principle of existence*, and also *all phenomena*, and also *teaching*. Because you can experience it and you can teach it to people. This is our responsibility: we have to transmit this dharma to the next generation. So, we can teach. That is *dharma*.

– From “Verse of Opening the Sutra” (July 23, 1986) at 6:06

So *dharma* actually means at least three things: *the principle of existence*, *phenomena*, and *teaching*. And it's implied that it means all three things at the same time.

Rounding out the Triple Treasure is *sangha*:

[Dōgen Zenji says:]

We take refuge in the Buddhist community because it is composed of excellent friends.

Sangha is a community, but it's not the usual sense of community, because this community has lots of people who try to follow the Buddha's way. [That's why] they are excellent friends for you.

After some explanation of the meaning of "excellent friends," he continues:

[...] This sangha is quite different from the usual sense of community. If people just gather and live together, it's not *sangha*. Each of you has to be an *excellent friend* to others, because you must be following Buddha's teaching. You must be following the essence of the universe, and the virtue of the universe, the functioning of the universe. And then you become excellent friends to others.

– From "Lay Ordination Lecture 3 of 7: Triple Treasure, Lecture 1" (March 8, 1986) at 14:00.

So we can say that the Way as *universal life* is the teaching of the universe, the *buddha-dharma*. And the community of people who are following the Way is the *sangha*.

And what is *taking refuge* in Buddha, dharma, and sangha? Katagiri Roshi says:

If so, what is taking refuge? What is the point? How can we realize, how can we touch that spirit of taking refuge which turns into motive power? Here it says:

The merit of having taken refuge in the Three Treasures inevitably appears when there is spiritual communion between the trainee and the Buddha.

Here it says "spiritual communion" between the Buddha and the practitioner, the Buddha and you. "Spiritual communion" means "interacting communion of appeal and response" (*kannō dōkō*, 感應道交).

In the talk, Katagiri Roshi vividly describes this appeal in terms of *prayer* – not prayer to an individual entity, but prayer to the whole universe. He continues:

And then, if you completely feel that spirit of the universe, and appeal for help, or appeal for the coming alive in your every day life, very naturally you can be one with the universe. That is the response.

In other words, if you try to reach out your hand to the universe, the universe reaches out its own hands. That is [spirituality, but in the] broad sense, it's really true. And then Buddha, the spirit of the universe, and you – the path of your life and the path of the universe – become one, interconnected, crossing each other.

That is called *dōkō*, of *kannō dōkō*. *Kan* means “appeal.” The *nō* of *kannō* is “response.” *Dō* of *dōkō* is “the path.” *Kō* of *dōkō* is “to cross.” So appeal and response come across, very quickly.

– From “Lay Ordination Lecture 3 of 7: Triple Treasure, Lecture 1” (March 8, 1986) at 33:20.

It is important to understand that this “appeal and response” with the universe is not about trying to get something specific. Rather, it is about *full communication* with the universe. In discussing *Blue Cliff Record* Case 36: “Ch’ang Sha Wandering in the Mountains,” Katagiri Roshi says it like this:

Satori (enlightenment) is found in the very simple movement (of wandering in the mountains) which is exactly fit into the rhythm of life. [You and the mountains] fit together; at that time there is full communication between you and the mountains. That is called *kannō dōkō* (感應道交) in Japanese.

– From “Blue Cliff Record Case 36: Ch’ang Sha Wandering in the Mountains, Talk 1” (December 1, 1982) at 16:42

It’s also important to understand that *kannō dōkō* or “interacting communion of appeal and response” isn’t a side topic here; it’s the main point. “Full communication” isn’t a step toward attaining enlightenment; full communication *is* enlightenment.

Again, this is important. A mistake that many academic researchers (and other people) make in trying to analyze *Fukanzazengi* is that – despite what Dōgen says, and sometimes despite even what they say themselves – they still assume that *really*

there must be an individual goal to attain here, *somehow*, if only we can figure out what it is. So naturally, in order to reach that goal, there must be some secret mental technique that Dōgen is perversely hiding from us.

If you assume that, you will not understand *Fukanzazengi*. It simply does not make sense when analyzed in that way.

So what do we assume instead? *Interactive communion of appeal and response with the universe, or full communication*. How can we actually experience this *total* communication? Katagiri Roshi says:

When can you see this? That is exactly *shikan*, or *wholeheartedness*.

– From “Lay Ordination Lecture 3 of 7: Triple Treasure, Lecture 1” (March 8, 1986) at 33:20.

Shikan (只管) here is the same word as in *shikantaza*, “wholehearted sitting.” This is the fundamental practice, here understood in the general sense that we can participate wholeheartedly in *any* activity.

Put another way, in taking refuge in dharma through the practice of *wholeheartedness*, we connect with the larger sense of ourselves which includes all things, all *phenomena*. Katagiri Roshi says:

So if you practice like this, very naturally dharma is coming to your life, and your life manifests yourself as dharma. So very naturally your life [manifests] as *total personality*.

Do you know the [term] *total personality*? Total personality is your personality *including* trees’ life, others’ life, all beings. Your life is penetrating to the past, present, future, and also trees, birds... Japan, China, all of the world... pebbles, air... and then your personality becomes *whole*. This is *total personality*.

– From “Depending on the Dharma” (August 3, 1988) at 11:30.

Total personality is an important term that Katagiri Roshi uses frequently. In his talks on *Fukanzazengi*, Katagiri Roshi says that sitting down in zazen is about sitting down in the core of our total personality.

... let's sit down in the core of your total personality. That is *buddha-nature*. And then this total personality, which is called *buddha*, is completely perfect and all-pervading. Dōgen Zenji says, "The origin of the way is perfect and all-pervading."

– From "Fukanzazengi: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 1" (June 9, 1979) at 56:36.

So it seems *the Way* is *total personality*, which is our personality in connection with the whole universe of space and time. And this is *buddha-nature*.

Bottomlessness of your personality is what is called *buddha*. We say *buddha*, or *vastness of your nature*, or *vastness of your capability*. [This is what] is called *buddha-nature*, or *buddha*, or *buddha-dharma*; we say so.

– From "Blue Cliff Record Case 52: Chao Chou Lets Asses Cross, Lets Horses Cross – Talk 1" (January 21, 1984) at 41:41.

But *total personality* is really not something abstract and separate from our day-to-day lives. In fact, Katagiri Roshi uses a term that might surprise people:

I told you yesterday [about] the *whole personality* or *total personality*; the personality that, according to general Buddhism, is *buddha-nature*, or according Buddhist psychology it is called *karma*.

That total personality has a double face. One face is [the] karma you have carried from the past. And the other face is [that] that total personality is completely beyond human criticism; that is really *buddha-nature*. You cannot know what karma is, because karma comes from the beginningless past, and is going to the endless future. That's why in *Fukanzazengi* Dōgen Zenji says, "The origin of the way is perfect and all-pervading."

And then also, if you do zazen, the original face of existence appears, manifests itself. That is, as Dōgen says in *Fukanzazengi*, [perfect and all-pervading]: the origin of the way, the origin of existence, is perfect and all-pervading. That is *buddha-nature*. If you do zazen, immediately [it] appears. That is what is called the original nature of existence manifesting itself. So Dōgen says in *Fukanzazengi*.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 2” (June 10, 1979) at 34:20.

So the “double face” of *total personality* is that it is *buddha-nature*, but simultaneously it is also *karma*: our ordinary, day-to-day lives, sometimes called “karmic life.” Another way of saying this is that *karma is buddha-nature*, and *buddha-nature is karma*. For many people, this may be surprising to hear, because it is considerably different from how *karma* is usually understood.

In the summer of 1980, Katagiri Roshi gave a two-week seminar on *karma*, which seemed to be largely about clarifying this issue. In the introduction to the transcripts, I attempt to summarize what he said:

The concept of *karma* is inextricably entwined with Buddhism itself. However, we should be careful to understand what Katagiri Roshi means by *karma*. *Karma* is not merely *action*, nor *cause and effect*; nor is it some kind of force that locks us into a certain destiny. According to Katagiri Roshi, *karma* is great energy that allows us to live, to relate to people and the world, and to move freely into the future.

– From the introduction by Kikan Michael Howard to Katagiri Roshi’s talks on *Karma*.

Overall, what this means is that our so-called ordinary “karmic” lives are actually extraordinary “buddha” lives. And as Katagiri Roshi says above: “If you do zazen, immediately [it] (this extraordinary nature) appears. That is what is called the original nature of existence manifesting itself.”

Why all the confusion around the word *karma*? It is partly because the word *karma* actually pre-dates Buddhism, and has a variety of meanings in different religious traditions. Plainly speaking, much of our common understanding of *karma* is coming from Hinduism or Brahmanism, not from Buddhism.

In fact, arguably, the understanding of the word *karma* is so confused, that in about the 4th century in India, in the development of the Yogachara teaching of Mahayana Buddhism, they came up with a new word to use instead. That word is *ālayavijñāna*, which means “storehouse consciousness.” This is a big topic, but for the moment, let’s simply understand that *ālayavijñāna* means basically the same thing as *karma*, only without some of the historical baggage.

And even earlier than that, Mahayana Buddhism introduced another new word: *tathāgatagarbha*, which means the same thing as *buddha-nature*. In fact, *tathāgatagarbha* is more or less where the term *buddha-nature* comes from. *Tathāgata* is another word for *buddha*, and it also implies *suchness*: it means something like “thus coming and going.” And *garbha* literally means “womb.” So we could think of *tathāgatagarbha* as “the origin of Buddha,” or “the origin of suchness.”

In Zen, *ālayavijñāna* and *tathāgatagarbha* are considered to be two aspects of the same thing. According to Katagiri Roshi, they are like a piece of paper with two sides. This means exactly the same thing as “karma is buddha-nature.”

The relationship between *ālayavijñāna* and *tathāgatagarbha* is a deep topic in Mahayana Buddhism which Katagiri Roshi discusses often, notably in his talks on *Genjōkōan* and on *The Awakening of Faith*. These terms will come up frequently later on, so we introduce them now.

But practically speaking, what does it mean to sit down in the midst of this *total personality* through *wholeheartedness*? Continuing his discussion of “interacting communion of appeal and response with the universe” (*kannō dōkō*), Katagiri Roshi says:

The *Saddharma Pundarika Sutra* (the *Lotus Sutra*) [talks about this]. If you read this just on the surface, it is kind of mysterious, but if you consider it deeply, it is very true. It says:

The Buddha answered the Bodhisattva Infinite Thought: “Good son! If there be countless hundred thousand myriad *kotis* (a very large number) of living beings suffering from pain and distress who hear of this Bodhisattva Regarder of the Cries of the World, and with all their mind call upon his name, the Bodhisattva Regarder of the Cries of the World will instantly regard their cries, and all of them will be delivered.

That is really *faith*, total security. The moment your mind is vibrated, you cannot believe this. But right in the middle of *wholeheartedness*, you can believe it, beyond your senses, because [...] there is total realization of you, total presence of your life, which is exactly settling down right here,

right now. That is called *wholeheartedness*. With wholeheartedness you call upon Avalokiteshvara.

In other words, if you really see deeply the total picture of the human world, *samsara* – how transient the world is, how fragile human life is – then you can hear the cries. And then if you hear the cries, very naturally the cries of the human beings are simultaneously the listener, so-called Avalokiteshvara. So immediately you can appeal for help, and simultaneously the universe reaches out to you with its hands. [...] You can see the path through which you and the universe are crossing each other.

And then how can you do this? That is by manifestation of your wholeheartedness. When you chant, when you repeat the name of Buddha, when you do *gassho*, you *do* it. And then, there is exactly the total presence of your life. That total presence of your life is exactly the same as the total presence of the universe, before you poke your head into it. And then you feel peaceful, simultaneously.

That is sitting zazen, exactly. You don't know; but even though you don't know, if you sit exactly, totally, with wholeheartedness, some part of your body feels it. You can feel peaceful, because your presence and the presence of the universe are exactly crossing each other.

– From “Lay Ordination Lecture 3 of 7: Triple Treasure, Lecture 1” (March 8, 1986) at 33:20.

It might seem surprising for Avalokiteshvara to appear in a discussion of Zen meditation, but this is common in Katagiri Roshi's talks. Avalokiteshvara, The Bodhisattva Regarder of the Cries of the World, is deeply tuning in to the feeling of the universe, which is what we do in zazen. Avalokiteshvara represents *compassion* in Buddhism – or another word might be *empathy*. The core of Zen is both wisdom and compassion.

If this seems religious, that's because it is – but in a sense of the word that doesn't involve dogmatism, or even theology. Katagiri Roshi often talks about religious practice, even “religious zazen,” but for him the word “religious” usually means something very close to “nondualistic.” In other words, “religious” here means basically the same as “wholehearted,” or *shikan* (只管). “Religious” zazen is “real” zazen – which means not clinging to ideas.

Yet we quickly get into discussions about whether Avalokiteshvara is a real entity or not. Katagiri Roshi says:

Who is Avalokiteshvara? *You*. Us. Exactly this body: *this is Avalokiteshvara*.

Who creates this Avalokiteshvara? It doesn't matter whether this Avalokiteshvara is a real, existing being or not. It doesn't matter. This is [that] Avalokiteshvara is exactly *you*, all of you!

– From “*Kokyō: The Ancient Mirror – Talk 2*” (October 19, 1986) at 27:13

So to study the Way is to take refuge in Buddha, dharma, and sangha. As we recite at the beginning of the Full Moon Precepts Ceremony:

Taking refuge is to return home, arousing a fresh and vivid mind, openly and enthusiastically seeking for perfect peace. Even though body and mind are subject to birth, change and death, this moment of returning home offers the opportunity for the continuous practice of Buddha nature, the ripening of the sweet milk of the long river.

This refers to the last line of Dōgen Zenji's *Genjōkōan*:

The wind of Buddhism makes manifest the great earth's goldenness, and makes ripen the sweet milk of the long rivers.

“Making manifest the great earth's goldenness” is our practice. This is to realize buddha-nature or *tathāgatagarbha* in our lives.

“The long river” is our life: not just our limited, personal life, but *all* life, stretching from beginningless past to endless future. This is *karma*, or *ālayavijñāna*. And through our practice, we *ripen* this sweet milk.

Our practice is to deeply taste this *ālayavijñāna* or *karma*, and in that way we turn it over to see its other aspect: *tathāgatagarbha*, the world of Buddha. This world is totally free and all-inclusive: “perfect and all-pervading.” This is, as Katagiri Roshi says, “the origin of the Way.”

We'll return to this topic often, culminating in the last chapter, where we discuss “the treasure store.”

Chapter 3: Practice-Realization

Paragraph 1 Part 2

爭假修證。

How could it be contingent on practice and realization? [SZ]

How could it be contingent upon practice and realization? [EB]

Commentary

“Practice and realization” is a translation of the term *shushō* (修證). *Shushō* is also translated as hyphenated “practice-realization,” for reasons we will see in a moment. Or, some translators say “practice-enlightenment.” Understanding this term is essential for understanding Dōgen Zenji’s teaching, because essentially it *is* Dōgen Zenji’s teaching.

The translation of *shu* (修) as “practice” seems straightforward, but the translation of *shō* (證) as “realization” is not. It is important not to assume what this “realization” means based only on the English word. Katagiri Roshi gave an entire talk on the subject of *shō*, which begins as follows:

I would like to explain a little more about the [word] “realization” [that] Dōgen Zenji uses very often here: “practice and realization.” I don’t know how you understand what *realization* is. I think this is my problem, how to translate this term in English. Well, English always uses “realization,” but I don’t know *how* you understand this.

Dōgen uses three [words in Japanese meaning] “enlightenment.” One is *kaku* (覺): “awareness,” “awakening.” The second is *satori* (悟り, or 悟あ in Chinese): usually “enlightenment.” The third is *shō* (證). [...] *Literally* it means “verification” or “proof.” Literally, okay? This is also *shō*: [to certify], or to prove, or to verify, or to witness. So three terms are often used by Dōgen, but in this case, “realization” is corresponding to the third one – “proof” or “verification,” literally translated. But [...] I don’t know what [English word] is best, so I have to explain a little bit about this one.

The first one and second one, *kaku* and *satori*, both are something which you can experience through the six senses. But *shō* translated as “realization” is a little more than that which you can experience or you can awaken [to]. [It has] a little deeper meaning than *kaku*, “awakening,” or *satori*, “enlightenment.”

So I don't know how to translate it, but maybe we can say *shō*, translated literally as *verification* or *witness*, means “actualizing the consummation of being.” [Or actualizing the] ultimate nature of being.

“Consummation of being” – how can I say it – is a place where everything synchronizes with each other. Well, according to [what Buddha said], I think [whether] animate being or inanimate beings, all [were] simultaneously enlightened when he attained enlightenment. He said, “I and heaven and earth [...] are the same and one root, where all living beings attain enlightenment simultaneously.” That is a *consummation of being*. Consummation of the ultimate nature of being is the same and one place where everything coexists in peace.

– From “*Bendōwa: Dōgen's Questions & Answers – Talk 5*” (March 15, 1987).

Katagiri Roshi then explains that *shō* is the same as “suchness” or “thusness.” We'll return to the topic of “suchness” in Chapter 11: “Practice Suchness Immediately.” He continues:

So *shō*, the consummation of being, is not [something] you try to manifest. No, you cannot do it, because this is exactly the *ultimate* state of existence. You don't know [it]. But the unique way is to let it manifest by virtue of making your water clear or calm. Or, practically speaking, you really devote yourself to do something thoroughly, with sincere heart, *exactly* do it: then, the consummation of being comes out, emerges from [that] naturally. That is our practice.

– From “*Bendōwa: Dōgen's Questions & Answers – Talk 5*” (March 15, 1987).

Katagiri Roshi returned to this topic many times during his years of teaching. This is important, so in the next section we'll look at another example where he discussed *shō*.

In one of his talks on the *Diamond Sutra*, Katagiri Roshi explained the distinction between *kaku*, *satori*, and *shō* in detail:

In Japanese, “enlightenment” is described by three different characters. One is *kaku*: “awareness.” The second is *satori* – you are very familiar with this term, *satori*. The third is *shō*: that is usually translated as “realization.”

Enlightenment, broadly speaking, is to know or to awaken to the real nature, the original nature of existence. The original nature of existence is *truth*.

According to the first term, *kaku*, awareness, this kind of enlightenment is to know, to experience the truth at the conscious level. Still that experience of enlightenment which is called *awareness* is at the conscious level. So whoever you are, if you practice *zazen* – or even though you don’t practice *zazen*, if you do your best to take care of your life, living in peace with all sentient beings with your best effort – at that time everybody can experience awareness, which allows you to touch the core of existence.

This is the first experience. Everyone can do this. But this experience of awareness is still at the conscious level. So even though you understand the universe, there is still some difficulty for us to know how we should put it into practice. We don’t know what to do, because the experience of the universe through awareness doesn’t work [appropriately enough] in our daily living.

The second is *satori*. *Satori* is a little deeper than the experience of awareness, because *satori* is that awareness which penetrates your body, your skin, muscle, bone, and marrow. You really understand what the universe is, how all beings exist, through your body and mind, skin, muscle, bone, and marrow. So your daily living is a little bit free from their difficulties, because you understand pretty well, and you know a little bit how to practice the universe in your daily living, how to practice the experience of *satori* in your daily living. In your daily living, maybe your attitude gradually becomes very gentle, compassionate to everybody.

But still this *satori* is not good enough, because it is still something which is going on at the conscious level. Sometimes you handle this *satori* at the

conscious level, sometimes you can get out of the conscious level, but still, it goes back and forth, so it's still very difficult for us to experience perfect stability in our daily living.

That is *satori*. Usually people understand Zen as cultivating the experience of *satori*; [they understand that] Zen practice gives us a chance to experience *satori*, and that is the final goal we are aiming at. But this is not the final goal, because the experience of *satori* is still tinged with something intellectual which is going on at the subconscious level.

The final goal is that you must be free from the experience of *satori*. That is the third, the one which is called *shō*, which literally means “verification.”

Verification which is called *shō* is oneness with the original nature of being. There is no gap between; exactly your daily living is perfectly in accord with the original nature of existence, the rhythm of the nature of existence.

That is the third one, which is called *shō*, usually translated as “realization.” This third enlightenment is the highest spiritual level, in which you can be free from awareness and *satori*. There is no trace of *satori*, no trace of awareness. That is called “verification” because you are already one with the original nature of existence even if you don't realize it. You are already right in the middle of the nature of existence. By this *shō* enlightenment your life is supported, helped constantly, regardless of whether you like or dislike it. That is the total picture of [the] existence you have.

This is enlightenment. That's why Buddha says, “Is there any dharma which the Tathāgata has fully known as ‘the utmost, right and perfect enlightenment’?” This is really pointing to the third enlightenment, which is called *shō*: perfect, right, supreme enlightenment. But if you get *something* at the conscious level, it is not real enlightenment; it is called awareness, or *satori*, et cetera. Real enlightenment which is called *shō* is nothing you can get in your hand. But, you can *be with it*, always, constantly.

– From “*Diamond Sutra, Talk 9: Emptiness*” (August 1, 1979).

An important point here is that *shō* is always present. Our practice is to “be with it.” Or sometimes Katagiri Roshi says “be right there,” or “right now, right here,” or “be right on.” We'll discuss this more in the next section on the *dharma vehicle*.

This *practice-realization* does not only happen in meditation; it functions in all parts of our lives. Katagiri Roshi often talks about Zen practice in the context of activities like music, painting, dancing... rock climbing, playing football... going to class, going to work... even daily activities like washing the dishes, going to the toilet, going to bed.

What does practice-realization look like outside of Zen meditation? In the following example, Katagiri Roshi doesn't use the term *practice-realization*, but he's talking about the same thing:

I always tell you: Zen practice is very simple. Very practically, compassionate attention penetrates from the top of the head to the tip of the toes. That means what?

[...] If you want to play the guitar, you cannot play the guitar with two hands, actually. Strictly speaking, you cannot play it with two hands: you have to play the guitar with two hands, your nose, your ears, your mouth, your consciousness, your head, your knowledge, your heart, your emotions, your past life, present life, future life; with composers, and audience, everything. And then, at that time, you can really play guitar. That is called *playing guitar*.

But we don't think that. We think, "Oh, I can play guitar." So Buddhism says, "No. You cannot play the guitar." [*He laughs.*] "But I can play the guitar!" It's not good enough. Try to practice until playing the guitar is completely tuning in the rhythm of the universe – including trees, birds, and your mouth, your eyes, your heart, your emotions, audience, and composer; everything. And then at that time, you are called a guitar player.

Do you understand? So you say, "I am a guitar player. I am a musician." You say it very simply: "I am a guitar player." "I am a painter." "I am a poet." Of course you are a poet; you are a guitar player, you are a musician, you are a painter. I understand. But it's not good *enough*. You are *not* a poet. "How come?" [*He laughs.*] A simple question: "How come? I am a poet. I am a writer." Of course you are a writer, you are a musician. But, *watch out* – okay? You are not a musician, you are not a writer: that means, you have to write something with all sentient beings. How? Practice. Continue to write, beyond like or dislike, until your writing is completely flowing just like water. If you [see] the pen, pencils, and your hands, and also your mind, your heart, your emotions, and your past life,

present life, future life – all are going on, moving. All that [melds so] that your pen and hands move to write, very naturally. It is pretty hard. But at that time, you are called a great writer, a great painter.

That's why we have to practice; we have to do fundamental practice as a writer, as a painter, as a poet. If you really want to support your life as a poet, or painter, or musician, you have to practice. Not for a certain period of time – for *long*. From the beginning to end, you have to do it.

And then at that time, you can say, "I am a guitar player, I am a musician." Even if you don't think so, people call you a guitar player. And then, people don't tell you, but very naturally people hire you, and people ask you to play guitar in public, before they put a certain name on you. So that's pretty good. Sometimes you don't know when you become a writer, or when you are a great musician. But it's not necessary [to know]. People ask you to play the guitar, or to write something. That is a great chance for you to practice, to continue to do it.

– From "*Diamond Sutra*, Talk 1: Introduction" (May 9, 1979) at 35:44

Often the question comes up of how we work with *feelings* in Buddhism, or sometimes this is framed as how to work with *like and dislike*. In Zen, there are no particular rules saying, "If you feel *this*, do one thing; if you feel *that*, do another thing," et cetera. If we want to be a writer, how do we do it? Katagiri Roshi says, "Continue to write, beyond like or dislike, until your writing is completely flowing just like water. "

And yet, if we never *experience* any feelings, our writing is likely to be pretty dull! The same goes for music, or really any pursuit. Our feelings are among the many *beings* that we practice with. They give us lots of information about what is going on in the world, what it is like to be a human being. "Full communication" or *kannō dōkō* is happening there. So we get to be with this information and then decide: what would be best to do.

So again, as we said in Chapter 1, our practice is not about eliminating feelings that we don't like, nor is it about chasing after feelings that we *do* like. We don't try to pick and choose; we do our best to be present in the midst of everything, and then take appropriate action. This is to be "flowing just like water."

The same is true of zazen. However, zazen is sort of a special case, where we make the practice as absolutely simple as we can, so that we can just be present. This is good practice for how to live our lives as a whole.

Since the practice is to “be right here,” or in other words to be present in the midst of everything, *practice* is intimately connected with *realization* – in fact, they are one.

The oneness of practice and realization is often presented as a key point of Dōgen’s teaching, if not his key point, period. A well-known statement from *Bendōwa* is:

To think practice and realization are not one is a heretical view. In the buddha-dharma, practice and realization are identical.

About this, Katagiri Roshi says:

So the points that Dōgen Zenji [makes] here: one point is that practice and realization must be one. And the second [point] is that practice and realization must go endlessly, and beginninglessly. [...] In other words, our practice must go forever.

I think this is not Dōgen Zenji’s idea, this is the essential point of Buddha’s teaching.

– From “*Bendōwa: Dōgen’s Questions & Answers – Talk 4*” (March 14, 1987).

“Practice and realization are identical” means there is no *thing* called “realization” that you (or anyone) can “have,” separate from ongoing practice. This is one reason why “practice and realization must go endlessly.”

“This is not Dōgen Zenji’s idea” means that fundamentally, Dōgen Zenji didn’t invent something new here. This is just Buddha’s teaching – both the teaching of the historical Buddha and the teaching of the universe. The expression may be refreshed, but the essential point is the same as it has ever been, or ever will be.

So, to rephrase this line of *Fukanzazengi*: “How could the Way, the functioning of the universe, depend on practice-realization?” How, indeed? Given what we’ve discussed about *the Way* and *practice-realization*, the question itself here might mean something different than we at first thought. We’ll continue to look at this question in the following chapters.

Chapter 4: The Dharma Vehicle

Paragraph 1 Part 3

宗乘自在、何費功夫。

The true vehicle is self-sufficient. What need is there for special effort?
[SZ]

The Dharma-vehicle is free and untrammelled. What need is there for one's concentrated effort? [EB]

The dharma vehicle is free and unrestricted, why should we expend sustained effort? [KR]

Commentary

We've mentioned that the term *dharma* has at least three meanings simultaneously: *the principle of existence*, *phenomena*, and *teaching*. Katagiri Roshi also says:

Dharma means that which is constantly supporting [or] upholding all beings, completely beyond human speculation.

– From “Verse of Opening the Sutra” (July 23, 1986) at 6:06.

This relates to the meaning of *dharma vehicle*.

“Dharma vehicle” here is also translated as “true vehicle,” “fundamental vehicle,” “ancestral vehicle,” and in other ways, but the word “vehicle” (乗) appears in most translations. What do we mean by “vehicle”?

“Vehicle” is a common term in Buddhism: there is often discussion of “two vehicles,” “three vehicles,” “five vehicles,” and these vehicles perhaps represent different teachings or different schools of Buddhism. Dōgen Zenji mentions some of these vehicles in this passage in *Bendōwa*:

You should also know that basically we lack nothing of highest enlightenment. Though we are forever endowed with it, since we are unable to

be in complete accord with it, we have a way of giving rise to random intellections, and by chasing them as if they were real, we stumble vainly on the great Way. Because of these intellections, flowers in the air of various kinds appear: thoughts of a twelve linked chain of transmigration, or of realms of twenty-five forms of existence, views of three vehicles, five vehicles, Buddha, no-buddha – they are endless. You shouldn't think that learning such intellectualizations is the right path of practice in the buddha-dharma.

But when you now totally cast aside all things and single-mindedly do zazen in accordance with the buddha-seal, then, beyond the realms of illusion and enlightenment, sentiments and calculations, untouched by the difference of unenlightened and enlightened, you immediately walk at ease beyond established forms and regulations and employ great enlightenment. What have those enmeshed in the traps and snares of words and letters to compare to this?

(From “Dōgen's *Bendōwa*,” translation by Norman Waddell and Abe Masao in *The Eastern Buddhist*, Vol. IV, No. 1, May 1971, p. 124-157.)

Buddhism, particularly Zen or Mahayana Buddhism, seems rare among religions in the degree to which it is willing to throw its own teachings under a bus to try to point in the direction of real truth. (See, for example, *The Heart Sutra*.)

But in these lines in *Fukanzazengi*, we don't seem to be discussing “vehicles” in the sense of different teachings or practices. Here we are discussing the *dharma* vehicle.

Katagiri Roshi discusses these lines in his talks on *Blue Cliff Record* Case 2: “The Ultimate Path Is Without Difficulty,” talking about the *dharma vehicle* in connection with two other terms from the case: “the Ultimate Path” and “the fundamental vehicle of transcendence.” He says:

In this pointer Engo Zen Master emphasizes the significance of “the task of the fundamental vehicle of transcendence.” In other words, that is the great path, or the Ultimate Path; he uses a different term [here], *the task of the fundamental vehicle of transcendence*. This is the main point in this pointer. Plainly speaking, this is the truth, or original nature of existence, or *dharma*. Dōgen Zenji said in *Fukanzazengi*, “The dharma vehicle is

free and unrestricted, why should we expend sustained effort?" So Dōgen uses the term *dharma vehicle*.

– From “*Blue Cliff Record Case 2: The Ultimate Path Is Without Difficulty, Talk 1*” (January 19, 1980).

Katagiri Roshi spends much of Talk 1 unpacking this; it's well worth reading, but a bit too much to include here. In Talk 2 he sums it up:

Yesterday I told you, the “Ultimate Path” is the same as “the task of the fundamental vehicle of transcendence.” Usually truth is regarded as something which exists far from us, which no one can touch, but I don't think Buddhism understands it in that way. The truth is always with us. So the characteristic of truth is completely something *transcendent*, which means beyond human speculation – good or bad, right or wrong. It makes all beings live in peace and harmony. That is characteristic of the truth or universe: unifying all things, beyond human judgement, good or bad, right or wrong.

So from this point, how can we approach truth, how can we reach this truth? That's why we have to manifest ourselves in the state of transcendence. “Transcendence” means the state of a person who is never tossed away by judgement, good or bad, right or wrong.

That's why in zazen we shouldn't judge ourselves, good or bad, right or wrong. Anyway right now, right here, all you have to do is to let the flower of your life force bloom. At that time, good or bad, right or wrong appears and disappears very naturally. But ... if you meddle with those thoughts, judgements, evaluations, [then] simultaneously the many kinds of [affective preferences] appears. That is a problem for us, which leaves human beings in confusion and bewilderment.

So in order to be one with the truth, we have to manifest ourselves in the state of a person who is never tossed away by thoughts and ideas. That means, yesterday I told you, under all circumstances we have to release and forget ourselves, and throw ourselves away to zazen when you have to do zazen. When we have to do gassho, we have to *do* that. At that time, you can really manifest yourself: bloom the flower of life force from moment to moment. Wherever you may be, it is just like a lotus flower.

That is “the task of the fundamental vehicle of transcendence,” which is called the Ultimate Path. That is really the great vehicle which you are right on. Truth is not something which we can think, we can envision, we can believe, but it is something that you have to *be right on*. That is the Ultimate Path. At that time, it is without difficulty. It’s really just to be right on the vehicle, which is absolutely transcendent of human evaluation.

– From “Blue Cliff Record Case 2: The Ultimate Path Is Without Difficulty, Talk 2” (January 20, 1980).

Normally when we hear the word “transcendence” we might think it means going beyond daily life, but in a sense this is the opposite. This transcendence is not about transcending reality, it’s about transcending our evaluations of it. It means not being stuck, just being *right on* daily life – right on the vehicle.

“Vehicle” implies that, at least when you get on it, you’ll be taking a ride. So at that point, “what need is there for one’s concentrated effort?” Katagiri Roshi discusses this later in Talk 1:

Zen is sometimes misunderstood by people because we don’t have a particular object which is called a divine entity, which is called God, which is called the soul, or whatever you say. [...] So very naturally, in the Buddhist world it might be easier for us to lose what is called *faith*, if you like. [*He chuckles.*] We use the term *faith* and *Buddhist faith*, et cetera. It’s pretty easy [to lose faith], because there is nothing to depend on.

We *want* [something]. But usually if you see something you want to depend on objectively, that is something different from your daily life – because we always have to research what it is. Buddha or Avalokiteshvara, whatever it is: you very naturally want to research what it is. That is ontology, philosophy, psychology. “What is it?” Always the question comes up. And that question really prevents you from releasing and forgetting yourself and throwing yourself into Buddha’s home.

[The question] is important, but you cannot be *obsessed* with it. That’s why Buddhas and ancestors constantly say, “Get one hundred percent.” If you want to perform gymnastics, get one hundred percent. How? Right now, right here, what should you do? Jump in. This is very practical...

because it is not the ontological object, it is something [where] you have to communicate very closely with your daily life. For this, what should you do? Jump into it. Throw yourself into Buddha's home.

Without this, it's very difficult. Particularly when you do zazen, this is the very fundamental practice for us, that's why we have to throw [ourselves] into zazen itself. If you always create some delusion or fascination within your mind, it is not perfect zazen. I always tell you, zazen must be *pure* zazen. You have to get one hundred percent. We have to grab zazen perfectly. If you can't, that is zero, completely zero. No ninety-nine percent. We don't believe this, but this is a very fundamental, important practice for us. Only when you throw yourself into zazen, at that time, what is called zazen blooms. That is what is called Buddha, Buddha's home.

But if you believe zazen is like this, well, you believe zazen is a particular practice. So Zen says zazen is *not* a particular practice; your daily life is practice. *Gassho*, working, having breakfast – we have to get one hundred percent. We should handle our daily life with wholeheartedness. This is what is called *shikan*.

At that time, your daily life becomes *vehicle*. What you call the task is “the task of the fundamental *vehicle* of transcendence.” *Transcendence* means completely there is no need for your effort; function comes from Buddha's world. Something takes care of you, if you do it. If you create your circumstances which are called perfect zazen, then perfect zazen takes care of you – even though you don't want it.

If you always see the zazen from your viewpoint, always there is a question. There is nothing to get, so that's why you are very skeptical: “Should I spend my whole life doing zazen which is useless? Nothing to get, nothing to develop?” Ridiculous. You cannot do this. But even though you don't know how much your life or your personality develops or not, well, if someone [has open eyes, they] know pretty well how much you have been developing.

Anyway, at that time (when your daily life becomes *vehicle*), there is no need for your particular, sustained effort. Why should we expend sustained effort? All you have to do is throw yourself into zazen. At that time, something helps you. That something is completely transcendent. Nothing to say. Nothing to do.

That's why that is "the task of the fundamental vehicle of transcendence." All you have to do is constantly you should be right on this vehicle, one hundred percent. That is really vast. Nothing holy or not holy, and nothing good or bad. All you have to do is just get the bar, with wholeheartedness.

– From "Blue Cliff Record Case 2: The Ultimate Path Is Without Difficulty, Talk 1" (January 19, 1980).

It may sound intimidating to have to get one hundred percent, but it isn't a test, it's an opportunity. Every moment is an opportunity to be on the vehicle.

We mentioned earlier that another term for "the fundamental vehicle" is "the great path." Dōgen Zenji says that the great path is "transcendence" or "going beyond" but it also is "complete actualization." Katagiri Roshi explains:

Dōgen Zenji [says this] very simply in *Zenki*, "The Whole Works." It's very beautiful words. [...]

The great path of the buddhas in its consummation is passage to freedom, is actualization.

"In its consummation" means in its ultimate nature. If you see it in terms of ultimate nature of being, at that time there are two meanings of "the great path of the buddhas." One is "passage to freedom" – that means *emancipation*. Always something goes beyond; goes beyond the framework of the table, or tape recorder, or Katagiri, or floor and lights, everything. Completely beyond. And [second,] it is also "actualization." We call [that] *genjō*. *Genjō* means complete actualization, complete manifestation. *Gen* means "manifestation," *jō* means "completion" or "achievement"... well, "completion" is better. So, "complete actualization."

This term *actualization* came up in the previous chapter, where Katagiri Roshi discussed the term *shō* or "realization" as "actualizing the consummation of being" or "actualizing the ultimate nature of being." What do we mean by "actualization"? He continues:

So showing your form called *gassho* is something *actualized*. But something actualized by you is not something you can see with your six senses – because it is a perfect actualization, beyond good or bad, right or wrong. Why? Because its nature is based on *emancipation*, the functioning of emancipation – *freedom*. The functioning of the passage to freedom.

That's why next Dōgen Zenji [says],

That passage to freedom in one sense is that life passes through life to freedom.

If you see life, immediately we can see life in terms of dualism. At that time, [there are] life and death. The same applies to death. This is natural; but the real picture of life is not something like this. That's why we have to see the real picture of life! Otherwise, it's very difficult to build up peaceful life, day to day. That's why ancestors and buddhas are always talking about this. Even though it is difficult for us, we have to think [about it], consider [it] deeply.

And also he explained,

When that actualization is taking place, it is without exception the complete actualization of life.

So the life you can see is not life opposed to death, or [life that] you handle by your feeling – good or bad, right or wrong, dislike or like. The life you can see is complete actualization. This is the form of life, feeling of life you can see, you can hear. So what is life? Life is something more than you can think.

And also he said,

It is the complete actualization of death.

That means when that actualization is taking place, it is complete actualization of death. So death is what? Death is something more than you can think, opposed to life. If you deal with death opposed to life, it scares you. But death is what? Death is complete actualization beyond like or dislike,

or good or bad, right or wrong, hatred or not-hatred. Completely beyond, because it is based on the functioning of freedom – passage to freedom.

So life passes through life to freedom, and death passes through death to freedom. Table passes through the table to freedom! This is perfect, complete actualization. This is a *form*. That's why form is important.

For instance, Ryokan Zen Master in Japan, who is pretty well known by Zen students. He looked like a shabby monk, not a usual monk. He didn't have a temple; he stayed in a very tiny hut, and he lived by begging. [It is an] interesting story around him. And right before he was going to die, he was asked by his disciples: "What do you think about life?" And he said: "A maple leaf is falling, showing its front and back."

This is life, for him. You can understand it, you know? What is life? Life is just like a maple leaf is falling. "Falling" means your life is marching toward death. [*He chuckles.*] Marching to the graveyard. And on the way to the grave, what happens? Showing your back, showing your front – that's it. Showing crying, showing pleasure – showing suffering, always. This is life.

Somebody asked me to write a calligraphy, so I added one more thing: death. And about death I said, "When [fall of the maple leaf] is taking place, it is no failure [to] fall." Do you understand? It is no failure in [falling]. In other words, right in the midst of falling, there is no failure.

"No failure" means completely beyond success and failure: just going. [*He laughs.*] No way. This is life; this is death. Because death is completely beyond.

And also, "completely beyond" is not abstract; it is completely something *actualized*, which is complete and perfect. That's why the scenery of Fall is beautiful. It's very beautiful. Sometimes it makes me pensive or sad, and feeling human impermanence. But as a whole, autumn is autumn. Through the fall of a single leaf, you can realize the whole world becomes autumn. So that's why the fall of a leaf is something more than the fall of a leaf – it's the total picture of autumn.

Is the total picture of autumn something abstract for us? No. The single maple leaf shows it exactly.

That is our life. [This is] Katagiri's life right now – next moment, I don't know if my life is going on or not. Right now, all I can do is just sit down

and talk about Buddha's teaching, anyway. That's it. Beyond good or bad, right or wrong, or like or dislike.

That is what Dōgen Zenji says (in *Zenki*, "The Whole Works"). It is a very beautiful first and second paragraph, talking about exactly the total picture of the human world.

– From "*Blue Cliff Record* Case 87: Medicine and Disease Subdue Each Other – Talk 2" (October 16, 1988) at 20:40

We've mentioned Mahayana Buddhism, of which Zen is a part. It's well-known that Mahayana means "Great Vehicle." What is perhaps less well understood is that this term is pointing not so much at the greatness of a doctrine of Buddhism, but rather at the greatness of reality. Katagiri Roshi talks about this in the introduction to his series of talks on *The Awakening of Mahayana Faith*, a foundational text of Mahayana Buddhism:

[In the word] *mahayana*, *maha* is "great," *yana* is "vehicle." In this book, *mahayana* is described [as] the essence of what is now, here, or the ultimate nature of what is here and now. Two meanings: one is what is the ultimate nature of what is here and now, and also the second meaning is "embracing." So *maha* means the essence or ultimate nature of what is here, now, [and] that *maha* is to embrace all sentient beings. That is the meaning of *maha*.

And the function of the *maha* is a kind of vehicle to carry all sentient beings; that's why we say "vehicle." So *Maha-yana*; *yana* means "vehicle." All sentient beings are carried on [it]. That is *mahayana*.

[...] I have to say more [on] Mahayana *faith*, [as in] *Awakening of Faith*. This book is [a] teaching of Buddhist faith: not the usual Hinayana Buddhist faith, but Mahayana Buddhist faith.

Mahayana is kind of the essence of the Buddhist faith, or [the] object of faith we believe in. Mahayana is the object of faith because *maha* means *essence of being* or ultimate nature of what is here and now, so that is really the object of our faith. But it is very pure, because the *maha* is the essence of being which embraces all sentient beings and carries them. So it is very pure function. That's why the object of faith is something very pure, beyond human control, human speculation. Completely pure and clean.

– From “*The Awakening of Faith* – Talk 1: Introduction and Invocation” (March 16, 1984).

The term *Hinayana* is now considered pejorative and we avoid using it. Humans being humans, in history the terms *Mahayana* and *Hinayana* were immediately assigned to groups of people, but we should consider that this is not the deeper meaning of these words. As we shall see in the next chapter, we might even think of these as two aspects of practice that work together.

Chapter 5: Free from Dust

Paragraph 1 Part 4

況乎全體迥出塵埃兮、孰信拂拭之手段。大都不離當處兮、豈用修行之腳頭者乎。

Indeed, the whole body is free from dust. Who could believe in a means to brush it clean? It is never apart from this very place; what is the use of traveling around to practice? [SZ]

Indeed, the Whole Body is far beyond the world's dust. Who could believe in a means to brush it clean? It is never apart from one right where one is. What is the use of going off here and there to practice? [EB]

Commentary

“The whole body” is *zenshin* (全身) in Japanese. *Zenshin* as “the whole body” also appears in Dōgen's *Ikka myōju*, “One Bright Pearl”:

Thus, the suchness and beginninglessness of this bright pearl is limitless. It is the one bright pearl of all the worlds in the ten directions; it is not described as “two” or “three.” Its whole body is a single true dharma eye; its whole body is the true body; its whole body is a single phrase; its whole body is radiance; its whole body is the whole mind. When it is the whole body, it is not obstructed by the whole body. It is round, round; it rolls round and round.

– From *Treasury of the True Dharma Eye: Dōgen's Shōbōgenzō*, Volume I-VII, by the Sōtō Zen Text Project, p. 225.

So perhaps we could say that “the whole body” means your personal body and mind, but also the entire universe in space and time.

Consider this verse, which is probably the source of the common Zen expression “stepping off the top of a hundred-foot pole” which is used by Dōgen:

百丈竿頭不動人、雖然得入未為真。百丈竿頭須進步、十方世界是全身。

The person unmoving atop a thousand-foot pole —
Even though they've entered, it's not yet the real thing.
They should step off the top of the thousand-foot pole;
The worlds in the ten directions are their entire body.

– Verse by Changsha Jingcen (長沙景岑) (dates unknown). From *Treasury of the True Dharma Eye: Dōgen's Shōbōgenzō, Volume I-VII*, by the Sōtō Zen Text Project, p. 321.

“Entire body” here is *zenshin*. So there is a sense of stepping into this vastness which contains everything... or rather, which *is* everything.

We'll come back to this poem in a moment.

What is this “dust” that the whole body is free from? Briefly, we could say *delusion*: delusion about our karmic life.

This gets us back into our discussion of *karma*, and the fundamental teaching that *karmic life* is not separate from the *total dynamic working* of the whole universe. Katagiri Roshi mentions this “dust” while speaking about the need to “just be there,” in other words just be present in buddha-nature:

... This is total dynamic working. You become exactly one.

That [is what Dōgen Zenji talks about] in the chapter “Buddha Nature.”
The terms here are a little bit difficult, but let me read it:

Therefore the self and environment of sentient being, whole
being is not in the least involved in the waxing influences of
karma, ...

... this is the usual worldly affairs, our karmic life...

... is not bred by illusory causations, does not come into being
naturally, is not practiced or realized through miraculous powers. Were sentient beings, whole being contingent on the power of karma or on causes or on coming into being naturally, then the

realization of all saints and the enlightenment of all Buddhas and the eye pupils of buddhas and patriarchs also will be produced in these ways, and they are not. The entire world is completely free of all dusts as object to the self. Right here there is no second person.

“Right here there is no second person”: [that is,] karmic life. How can you be free from karmic life? By realization of the karmic life, you can be free from karmic life.

But what do we mean, “realization of karmic life?” That is still vibration of the mind (i.e., a subtle form of thinking). You have to understand what karmic life is. [*Real*] karmic life is not the karmic life separate from this one world, Buddha’s world. But if you say “by realization of the karmic life I will be free from karmic life,” this is already you believe that karmic life is separate! So that’s why here it says [that] karmic life is exactly Buddha’s world, all sentient [beings,] whole being. That means the whole universe.

If so, do we believe [there is] no karmic life? Yes [there] is; here is karmic life! Because it is very closely connected with the one world, so-called *whole being*; that’s why it exists.

If so, can we not be free from it? But you can be free from it, because [...] “free from” means [there is] no karmic life, because it is exactly connected with the one world, so-called whole universe. That means the karmic life is exactly the whole world by itself – not karmic life is the whole world, karmic life *exactly whole world*, no partition between. This is the reality of karmic life, the reality of the samsaric world, which is constantly going...

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986) at 15:16

That, in brief, is why “the entire world is free from dust.” Yet we do not deny the conventional reality: “Hey, look! Dust!” Yet the entire world is *free* from it.

That is basically the dynamic of what follows in this chapter... with some exciting historical drama thrown into the mix.

“Who could believe in a means to brush it clean” is a reference to *The Platform Sutra* and the well-known story of the Sixth Ancestor, which is considered a foundational story in Chinese Buddhism.

In the story, the Fifth Ancestor, Great Master Hung Jen, challenges his monks to “use the wisdom-nature of your own original mind to compose a verse”; the monk who understands and expresses the great meaning will become his successor. The top student Shen Hsiu (Japanese: Jinshū) writes a verse comparing Buddhist practice to brushing dust from a mirror to keep it clean. The underdog student Hui Neng (Japanese: Daikan Enō) composes a responding verse, and becomes the Sixth Ancestor.

So although the word “mirror” does not appear in *Fukanzazengi*, “mirror” is implied by “brushing it clean.” But *Fukanzazengi* says “the whole body” is far beyond the world’s dust. How is “the whole body” related to the mirror?

The mirror is a common image in Zen Buddhist literature, and it is a deep subject, a bit challenging. Very briefly, we might say that the mirror is the absolute truth which is like a spacious sky, and also it is that which reflects all things, all phenomena, all *dharma*s. So perhaps we can say that the mirror reflects the whole body; the whole body is the reflection of the mirror. This experience “is never apart from one right where one is.”

For a deeper dive into the meaning of *mirror* in Zen, see Katagiri Roshi’s commentary on Dōgen’s Zenji’s *“Kokyō: The Ancient Mirror”*. Katagiri Roshi also talked about zazen being like a mirror in *“Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 5”* (June 13, 1979).

Returning to *The Platform Sutra* and “brushing it clean”: Katagiri Roshi tells the whole story with commentary, but let’s just look at what he says about the verses:

[Shen Hsiu’s] poem is pretty well-known by everyone as one of the Zen stories:

The body is a Bodhi tree,
The mind like a bright mirror stand.
Time and again brush it clean,
And let no dust alight.

And also later Hui Neng wrote his poem. His poem is:

Originally Bodhi has no tree,
The bright mirror has no stand.
Originally there is not a single thing:
Where can dust alight?

Sometimes people deal with the two poems separately, and evaluate which is right, which is wrong, but I don't think that is the right understanding. Both poems work together in our practice. I think you cannot separate them.

So, according to Shen Hsiu, I think he stands always in the dualistic world, looking at himself and [trying] to reach the buddha-nature. From this point, "the body is a Bodhi tree": we are buddha-nature but we are not buddha-nature, so we have to realize, we have to see into our own nature. [...] "The mind like a bright mirror stand": this is exactly the same as the teaching of nirvana. So, we are Buddha. "Time and again brush it clean": but we are living in the human world, so it's easy for us to get "dusty"; that's why we have to always brush it clean. "And let no dust alight." So, constantly practice.

This is one aspect of the practice: seeking for the truth, constantly, from the beginning to end. Even if you attain enlightenment, even if you become buddha, constantly we have to seek.

And on the other hand, the other aspect of practice is to descend to the human world to share your life with all sentient beings. [This is the spirit of Hui Neng's poem.] "Originally Bodhi has no tree, the bright mirror has no stand": because our foundation is already buddha-nature, so there is no particular thing to discuss or to forget. So constantly we have to stand up there, and then we can deal with the human world. "Originally there is not a single thing: where can dust alight?" So, we have to descend to the human world and save all sentient beings.

– From *"Platform Sutra – Talk 1"* (March 6, 1987) at 47:57.

If "originally there is not a single thing," why does that mean that we have to "descend to the human world and save all sentient beings"? Here let's return to the poem we quoted at the beginning of the chapter:

The person unmoving atop a thousand-foot pole —
Even though they've entered, it's not yet the real thing.
They should step off the top of the thousand-foot pole;
The worlds in the ten directions are their entire body.

We could say that the first part of the poem, “standing unmoving atop a thousand foot pole,” is realization that “there is not a single thing” – that is, realization of “emptiness.” That’s hard practice! Even if we wanted to, we could not stay there – because “emptiness” is not really “nothingness,” it’s “everythingness.” So rather than keep “ascending” to a pure practice, we need to come down. That’s where we realize that we share our lives with all beings.

And yet, we need to climb that thousand-foot pole. This matter of both Shen Hsiu’s and Hui Neng’s practices working together is revisited during the questions and answers:

Question: Hojo-san? If Shen Hsiu’s poem speaks to one aspect of our life reality, and Hui Neng’s poem speaks to another aspect, is real reality beyond both of them?

Katagiri Roshi: Yes. And they work together.

– From “Platform Sutra – Talk 1” (March 6, 1987) at 1:02:08.

So although the line “who could believe in a means to brush it clean” might initially seem to be supporting the verse attributed to the Sixth Ancestor Hui Neng over the verse attributed to Shen Hsiu, keep in mind that the next words in *Fukanzazengi* are, “and yet.” As Katagiri Roshi states above and on other occasions, these perspectives are two aspects of the same reality, and they work together. They are two sides of the same coin, and Dōgen’s “and yet” is basically flipping the coin.

Yet, in large part due to the *Platform Sutra*, it is commonly understood that there was a “Northern School” and a “Southern School” in early Zen, and that the Northern School represented “gradual enlightenment,” while the new Southern School represented “sudden enlightenment” – and the Southern School is regarded as superior. That is the story that we often hear. However, this does not exactly seem to be Dōgen Zenji’s understanding, nor Katagiri Roshi’s.

Katagiri Roshi even notes that Dōgen Zenji refers to the *Platform Sutra* as “a forged writing.” According to Dōgen:

The essence of *Buddhadharma* has never been to see into one's own nature. Which of the seven past Buddhas or twenty-eight Indian patriarchs ever said that Buddhadharma consisted merely of seeing into one's own nature? It is true that the sixth patriarch spoke about this question in the *Platform Sutra*, but as this is a forged writing, it cannot be said to represent his true teachings, or to have the transmission of the dharma. We descendants of the Buddha shouldn't rely on it.

– From *Zen Master Dōgen: An Introduction with Selected Writings*, Chapter 10: “A Monk at the Fourth Stage of Meditation (*Shi-zen Biku*)”, translated by Yuho Yokoi with Daizen Victoria. This is quoted in “*Platform Sutra – Talk 1*”.

First, an explanation: “to see into one's own nature” is *kenshō* (見性), a term that many Zen students will recognize. *Kenshō* is usually understood as “an enlightenment experience,” which isn't necessarily wrong. Two points here: *kenshō* (見性) is not the same as *shō* (證) or “realization,” which we discussed in Chapter 3: “Practice-Realization.” Instead, *kenshō* is considered to be basically the same as *satori*.

And there is a sort of controversy about this, in that the *Platform Sutra* more or less says that *kenshō* is the point of Buddhist practice, while Dōgen more or less says that that's ridiculous, as above. This is relevant because *kenshō* is associated with “sudden enlightenment.”

Basically, the whole discussion regarding “sudden enlightenment” or “gradual enlightenment” presupposes that the goal of practice is *enlightenment* – meaning *satori*, or in this case *kenshō*. But as we discussed in Chapter 3, that is not the goal of Dōgen's Zen.

But back to the forgery. Katagiri Roshi answers a question about this:

Question: So, Dōgen considered this a forgery?

Katagiri Roshi: Uh, not only Dōgen. I think the introduction written by Echū, who was one of Hui Neng's disciples, [talks about this]. Originally the *Platform Sutra* [was] written by one of the Sixth Patriarch's disciples, but he didn't publish it, and then other monks, other disciples, always carried it, and passages which [the] other disciples had [directly heard of]

the Sixth Patriarch's teaching were added to this original version. That's why [it's] "mixed up."

That is the general understanding, in Japan, in China, about this. So it's not *exactly* the Sixth Patriarch's teaching. We are disappointed if we [hear] that, but still we use this Sixth Patriarch's *Platform Sutra* as one of the Zen Buddhist textbooks.

So that's why Dōgen Zenji criticizes [it]... [Although] criticism is [not the right word]. Dōgen Zenji tries to let us know what the *real* teaching of the Sixth Patriarch is, instead of putting it down.

– From "*Platform Sutra – Talk 1*" (March 6, 1987) at 54:25.

It's not clear what introduction Katagiri Roshi is referring to above, but "Echū" probably refers to National Teacher Dazheng, Nanyang Huizhong (675-775 CE), a disciple of the Sixth Ancestor who often appears in kōans and is the source of several literary phrases used by Dōgen. In *Sokushin Zebutsu* ("This Mind Itself Is Buddha"), Dōgen approvingly quotes National Teacher Dazheng as he, among other things, criticizes "folk stories" or "vulgar tales" added to *The Platform Sutra* that "erase" the true meaning of the Sixth Ancestor's teaching:

"When I was wandering about some time ago, I often encountered this type. These days, they're particularly flourishing. They gather assemblies of three to five hundred and, gazing up at the Milky Way, tell them, 'This is the message of the South.' They revise the *Platform Sutra*, mixing in vulgar tales and erasing the sage's intent, misguiding and confusing later followers. How could it represent the oral instruction? How painful that our tradition is so ruined!"

– From *Treasury of the True Dharma Eye: Dōgen's Shōbōgenzō, Volume I-VII*, by the Sōtō Zen Text Project, p. 156.

It seems that at least in some circles, it has always been understood that the *Platform Sutra* contains revisions by more than one person, some of which are problematic.

Western historical scholarship may be catching on to this point of view. John R. McRae's *The Northern School and the Formation of Early Ch'an Buddhism* provides a compelling look at the history behind the composition of the *Platform Sutra*. Here we learn – to summarize briefly – that the entire notion of a "Northern School" and

“Southern School” was basically the invention of one historical person: the monk Shen Hui, who (like National Teacher Dazheng, above) claimed to be a disciple of the Sixth Ancestor, Hui Neng. Shen Hui should not be confused with Shen Hsiu, the alleged author of the “brush it clean” verse. Shen Hui, we learn, essentially weaponized the concept of “sudden enlightenment” as a means to attract religious adherents, and probably invented the poetry contest story as a means to that end. So successful was Shen Hui in presenting his simplified version of Zen, that for hundreds of years the Buddhist establishment essentially avoided discussing the practice of Zen meditation in public, for fear of being accused of the so-called “gradualist fallacy.” This may be an oversimplification of the story – but perhaps not by much.

From this perspective, *Fukanzazengi* could be seen as Dōgen’s Zenji’s effort, about five hundred years later, to clarify the relationship between so-called sudden and gradual, liberating Zen meditation from these extreme views. Whether or not this was Dōgen’s exact intent, such a liberation is necessary in order to understand Dōgen’s view of Zen meditation.

The introduction to McRae’s posthumously released *Zen Evangelist: Shenhui, Sudden Enlightenment, and the Southern School of Chan Buddhism* sums up the general point:

McRae’s meticulous analysis of the Northern school materials reveals the distortions and biases of the received tradition. To pick a single example, McRae takes to task the standard narrative that Northern teachers advocated a gradual path—that they viewed Buddhist practice as constituting a step-by-step ascent toward awakening. Instead, McRae shows that Northern teachers taught something closer to ‘constant practice’ — an approach that anticipates later Sōtō Zen teachings in Japan. For the Northern school, Chan practice was not a means to achieving liberation so much as a moment-to-moment re-cognition and affirmation of what is already the case, that is, of one’s abiding *bodhi*.

– From *Zen Evangelist: Shenhui, Sudden Enlightenment, and the Southern School of Chan Buddhism* by John R. McRae.

This is perhaps pretty good. However, we should note that – notwithstanding whatever shenanigans happened in history – an understanding of the harmony of “sudden” and “gradual” probably goes back at least to the time of Bodhidharma, if not further. (The “Two Entrances” treatise attributed to Bodhidharma could be seen

in this way). And if we look at the Zen literature between Bodhidharma and Dōgen, we can see that such an understanding never completely went away.

For example, in *Blue Cliff Record* Case 38: “Feng Hsueh’s Workings of the Iron Ox,” the pointer to the kōan says:

If we discuss the gradual, it is going against the ordinary to merge with the Way: in the midst of a bustling market place, seven ways up and down and eight ways across.

If we discuss the sudden, it doesn’t leave a hint of a trace; a thousand sages cannot find it.

If, on the other hand, we do not set up sudden or gradual, then what? To a quick person, one word; to a quick horse, one blow of the whip. At such a time, who is the master? As a test, I cite this to see.

(From *The Blue Cliff Record*, translated by Thomas Cleary & J.C. Cleary.)

Katagiri Roshi discusses this pointer in detail in “*Blue Cliff Record* Case 38: Feng Hsueh’s Workings of the Iron Ox, Talk 1”. It is not saying that “sudden” is best or “gradual” is best; once again the point is that we need both, according to Katagiri Roshi. Since the *Blue Cliff Record* originated in the Rinzai school – supposedly identified with “sudden enlightenment” – the nuanced take on the sudden here is rather striking. And this more universal view is by no means limited to this one case. Or, for example, in the *Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness*, we have the lines:

Now there are sudden and gradual
in connection with which are set up basic approaches.
Once basic approaches are distinguished,
then there are guiding rules.

Katagiri Roshi comments on this:

Historically we use the terms Sudden and Gradual to describe the Southern and Northern Schools. The school of Hui-neng is Sudden Zen Buddhism. Sudden means you are already Buddha, so there is a Sudden realization. The school of Shen-hsiu is called Gradual Zen Buddhism. Be-

cause you must practice to gradually attain enlightenment, to purify body and mind. So this sutra says there are sudden and gradual, in connection with which are set up basic approaches.

“Basic approaches” means that we should understand the real meaning of the teachings given by Shen-hsiu, founder of the Northern School, and that we should understand through and through the teachings of the Sixth Patriarch, Hui-neng, founder of the Southern School.

– From Katagiri Roshi's talks on *Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness* (November 7, 1983 to January 1, 1984), transcribed by Earl Broadbent, edited by Jeffrey Broadbent.

Note that again, the “Northern School” and “Southern School” are given equal time. So, there is a long history of this view before we arrive at what Dōgen Zenji says in *Bendōwa*:

Opening the books of scripture is so that, clearly knowing what the Tathagata teaches on the gradual and sudden practices, when we practice in accordance with these teachings, we invariably gain verification of them; it is not so that, wasting our thinking and calculating, we try in vain to assess their merit for attaining bodhi.

– From *Treasury of the True Dharma Eye: Dōgen's Shōbōgenzō*, Volume I-VII, by the Sōtō Zen Text Project, p.193.

This is perhaps referring to an earlier understanding of sudden and gradual in the teachings of the Buddha, but the meaning is about the same. The word “verification” here is once again *shō* (證), which we discussed earlier. This is not a coincidence.

But if we need both approaches, why did Hui Neng become the Sixth Ancestor and not Shen Hsiu? This is a pretty good question, which someone actually asked:

Question: Hojo-san, if in the two poems one isn't closer to the truth than the other poem, why did the Fifth Patriarch make Hui Neng the Sixth Patriarch, rather than both of them? ... Or neither of them, you know? [*He chuckles.*]

Katagiri Roshi: Because, as Dōgen Zenji mentions, “no buddha-nature” is *pretty close* to pointing out what the truth is.

It's not evaluating both of them, which is right, which is wrong. On the other hand, do you know [the story with] Kassan and Jōzan (Jiashan Shanhui and Dingshan Shenyong) in the chapter “Life and Death” (*Shoji* in *Shōbōgenzō*)? Dōgen Zenji quotes two sentences: “If there is a buddha, [there is no life and death]. If there is no buddha, [we are not confused by] life and death.” Something like that; I don't remember exactly. [...] And then [the two monks] went to see the teacher (Chan Master Fachang of Mount Damei), to evaluate which is right, which is wrong – which is *close* to the truth. Kassan [asks] the teacher, “Which of us is pretty close to the truth?” And [the teacher] says, “Maybe [tomorrow]; please come again.” He didn't answer. The next day Kassan [comes] again to see the teacher and ask the same question. And then [the teacher] says, “One who doesn't ask is closer to the truth. One who tries to know which is close is not close.”

That means “no buddha-nature.” “No buddha-nature” is *pretty close*, pretty close to the buddha-nature. [*He chuckles slightly.*]

[This is the same as the story of Hui Neng.] Hui Neng says, “Originally Bodhi has no tree, the bright mirror has no stand.” So it always talks about what the foundation is, and then, “Originally there is not a single thing: where can dust alight?” So constantly his basic foundation is found in *no buddha-nature*, there.

– From “*Platform Sutra – Talk 1*” (March 6, 1987) at 1:05:55

Even so, it's not one or the other. Returning to the *Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness*, the next lines say:

But even though the basis is reached and the approach comprehended,
true eternity still flows.

Katagiri Roshi's comment:

This means that if you practice hard, research and study, teach and practice for many years, then you can experience what we call the absolute, or enlightenment. Very slightly you can glance at true eternity, eternal life.

You will never be able to explain it, but as a practical matter you will be able to see a little bit of it. That's pretty good for us.

But if you try to experience this, it will be hard and take a long time, because the eternal life is a really huge mansion. You have to build up that mansion by means of psychology and philosophy and other subjects. And if you start to teach you have to teach this huge mansion, and it really takes time.

But if you experience it very naturally the eternal life is in your heart. So even if there are some aspects you cannot explain you can still demonstrate the eternal life.

If people look at someone who has experienced this, for example Shenshui, the founder of the Northern School, they will respect him as a saint. As a pure being. "Even though the basis is reached and the approach comprehended" means that he can walk step by step according to the Buddha's teaching. True eternity still flows; true eternity is always shown.

– From Katagiri Roshi's talks on *Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness* (November 7, 1983 to January 1, 1984), transcribed by Earl Broadbent, edited by Jeffrey Broadbent.

Although it may be helpful to challenge the conventional misconceptions on this topic, it's important to note that the debate over "sudden" and "gradual" is not the primary point in Buddhism, and it could even be seen as a distraction. In another talk, Katagiri Roshi says:

Zen history says Sōtō Zen is "gradual enlightenment," Rinzai Zen is "sudden enlightenment." It's ridiculous! [*He laughs.*] If you talk about this, it's ridiculous. If you're really crazy about this discussion, you don't understand Zen Buddhism, you don't understand Buddha's teaching, you don't understand human life. [*He chuckles.*] History is history. Don't worry about it. If you see someone who is interested in history, let him do that. But don't be involved in it too much.

– From "*Blue Cliff Record* Case 45: Chao Chou's Seven-Pound Cloth Shirt, Talk 1" (May 25, 1983) at 30:00

One reason why the discussion of “sudden enlightenment” or “gradual enlightenment” is “ridiculous” may be that, as we mentioned earlier, the primary point in Dōgen’s Zen is not *enlightenment* (*satori*) at all, it is *continuous practice*, or *practice-realization* (*shushō*).

Another reason, probably, is that endlessly discussing the practice... is not actually *doing* the practice.

So... heeding Katagiri Roshi’s advice, we’ll leave it at that.

Chapter 6: A Hairsbreadth Deviation

Paragraph 2 Part 1

然而毫釐有差天地懸隔、違順纔起紛然失心。

And yet, if there is a hairsbreadth deviation, it is like the gap between heaven and earth. If the least like or dislike arises, the mind is lost in confusion. [SZ]

And yet, if there is the slightest discrepancy, the Way is as distant as heaven from earth. If the least like or dislike arises, the Mind is lost in confusion. [EB]

Commentary

The first two characters here (然而) are usually translated as some variation of “and yet,” “however,” “nevertheless,” or “but.” These words are important, as we began to explore in the previous chapter. Here Dōgen presents the other side of the equation: the origin of the way is perfect and all-pervading, *and yet...* Or perhaps we could say, “and also.”

The specific term “a hairsbreadth deviation” appears in the *Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness*:

A hairsbreadth deviation
will fail to accord with the final attunement.

Or, put more simply:

A hairsbreadth deviation, and you are out of tune.

Katagiri Roshi comments on this:

If you miss the beat even slightly you cannot fit into the rhythm of music. You slip off. So regardless of whether we understand or not, our practice is to try to tune into the rhythm of music.

Regardless of whether you understand or not, you should keep your eyes open to how to tune in, because you are Buddha. Because you have to grow that seed of buddha nature. So you have already a great rhythm of music in your heart. Trying to tune into it is our practice. If you don't, immediately there is a gap. That slight gap is huge, like the gap between heaven and earth. So it is pretty hard to live in peace and harmony.

In the *Shōbōgenzō* Dōgen Zenji says that if you wish to understand the seed of buddha nature you should know that it is precisely the causal conditions of time and season. That is a big term; practically speaking it means time and space becomes fresh from moment to moment. It means there is no constant name that can apply to you. Good, bad, whatever. Nothing. Always you are fresh. So you have to live in this state of freshness. That is Buddhist logic.

– From Katagiri Roshi's talks on *Song of the Jewel Mirror Awareness* (November 7, 1983 to January 1, 1984), transcribed by Earl Broadbent, edited by Jeffrey Broadbent.

Discussions of *a gap* or *separation* are fundamental in Katagiri Roshi's teaching – so much so that those terms appear in well over half of his talks. Equally numerous are discussions of the opposite, which would be *samadhi*, “one-pointedness,” or “total acceptance,” et cetera, which are how we live in the state where “time and space becomes fresh from moment to moment,” as he says above. Or as he says in “Fukanzazengi – Talk 1” (June 9, 1979), “You must accept zazen as total activity which is vividly alive from moment to moment.” We also call this *freedom*, or *liberation*.

The gap is the discrimination of consciousness, the mind. It seems to come down to, this is how consciousness works. This is what Katagiri Roshi calls *the dualistic world*.

One good discussion of this is in a talk on *Blue Cliff Record* Case 51 – where, one might observe, someone raises almost the same question as Dōgen:

Question: Um, I have a question about... A lot of times I wonder why I'm on this path, and why humans constantly are looking for enlightenment, or going back to the true life. How did we ever get off the road? Why? Is it just solely to learn? Or... why? Why did we ever come out, why did we ever try to separate ourselves?

Katagiri Roshi: Separate from ... ?

Questioner: From the life force. Why [do] we choose to pretend like we're separate from the oneness?

Katagiri Roshi: Uh-huh. Because we have a mind. We have consciousness.

The energy of the consciousness is to separate, analyze, you and object and everything. This is the energy of consciousness and your mind.

So very naturally, you can slip off from the life force itself. On the other hand, by analyzing, synthesizing, and trying to understand your object and yourself, then that is called *the self*.

You know that Descartes says, "I think, therefore I exist." Okay? [*He chuckles.*] So, you cannot ignore that energy of mind. Thanks to the energy of your mind, you can appreciate the presence of the self.

That is called *self*. But the energy of the self means the quality of the self has the great power to bring the harmony to your life – looking at this life, so-called present, and past, and future, including life and death. This is the energy of the self.

Energy of the self is very powerful because [we are not only] looking at *this* life, in terms of making [a] better living, conflicting with or fighting each other – not like this. Like birds, and insects, and woodchucks.

I always say, "woodchuck." [*He laughs.*] (*Transcriber's Note:* It seems possible he means "squirrel" here.) Woodchuck is always living in the trees, and dogs walk under the tree – immediately, [*whoosh*], you know? But this action is to see his life in terms of instinct. He is always looking at his life [as] just a small world, in terms of instinct.

But the energy of the self is very powerful to look at this life and [other lives], all the world – understanding as a whole, as a one. That is a quality of the self. That quality of the self is very vital. So that is called *energy, life force*.

Life force itself is simultaneously birth, your life. Life force is something coming up [...]. That is just like spring water gushing out from the ground.

So "let's return to the source" means life force [is] constantly gushing out. That is, when [...] life force comes up, it is called *birth*. And when you are born in this world, simultaneously you have a mind and consciousness.

So [you] analyze, synthesize. [...] In other words, the energy of the consciousness and mind comes from life force itself. You cannot ignore it.

So thanks to the life energy of the consciousness [...] you can see, you can justify, you can confirm *you*, so-called *the self*. That energy of the self is not looking at only this life, but a big world: past, present, future, *as a whole*, as a one. This is the energy of the self.

And then if you understand like this, then we can return to this energy again. That is called *spiritual teaching*.

So...

So.

[Laughter.]

No particular reason why we have to do it, because we already are there. So all we have to do is just to learn where we are: what is the self, what is the consciousness. Not analyzing [and] synthesizing the consciousness, but by the consciousness we should know the limitation of the consciousness. *[He chuckles.]* In other words, through the consciousness we should learn what the consciousness is. Because consciousness is nothing but the energy of life force.

So we should learn through the consciousness. Very naturally you can know limitation of consciousness *by* the consciousness. *[He chuckles.]* Alright?

– From *“Blue Cliff Record Case 51: Hsueh Feng’s What Is It? – Talk 2”* (January 18, 1984) at 1:06:30

This matter of the energy of life coming from the “self” – and here we are not entirely talking about “Big Self” with a capital S – is deep. This is Buddhist psychology, and it is pervasive in Katagiri Roshi’s talks. In particular, in the Yogachara school of Mahayana Buddhism, this relates to the seventh of eight consciousnesses: *manas*, which Katagiri Roshi translates as “ego consciousness.” A full discussion of *manas* is beyond the scope of this presentation, but among the best places to start studying this is in Katagiri Roshi’s series of talks on Dōgen Zenji’s *Genjōkōan*, which includes an entire talk on *manas*.

“Like” and “dislike” are also part of consciousness, cognition. The specific phrase “like or dislike” appears in perhaps over a hundred of Katagiri Roshi’s talks. We should understand that we are not trying to *eliminate* like and dislike, but as Katagiri

Roshi says above, to “know its limitation.” In this way, we can work with like and dislike, instead of allowing it to work on *us*.

We'll return to how to work with like and dislike, good or bad, et cetera, in Chapter 9: “Take the Backward Step,” Chapter 15: “Have No Design on Becoming a Buddha,” and probably in many other places.

Katagiri Roshi also mentions mentions “the gap between heaven and earth” in the same talk on *Blue Cliff Record* Case 51. The pointer to the case says:

Even if you arrive immediately at the point of solitary liberation, you haven't avoided looking back to the village gate from ten thousand miles away.

Katagiri Roshi comments:

“Even if you arrive immediately at the point of solitary liberation” means [even if you have] oneness of the mountain and you who are climbing the mountain – you say, “I get it!” You get exactly a feeling of oneness, but at that time it is already something you can see objectively, so that oneness is not *real* oneness. That oneness is *perception* of the oneness, not *the last word* of the oneness. The last word of the oneness is constantly you must be alive right in the middle of oneness. *Constantly*.

If you *think* it, that is you immediately create a huge gap, just like between heaven and earth. That's why here it says, “Even if you arrive immediately at the point of solitary liberation, you haven't avoided looking back to the village gate from ten thousand miles away.” Anyway, you are just haunting the [fields and forests]. It's a [ghost story].

The other day I went to Milwaukee, and one of the Tibetan Buddhist groups taught me a very interesting... I don't want to tell this story because it's a little bit... I'm hesitating. [*He laughs a little.*] But anyway, whatever [this person] does, he is always very strongly imaginative about Avalokiteshvara, [the bodhisattva of] compassion. He tries to create the energy of Avalokiteshvara, so-called compassion, whatever he does. Particularly when he has excitement, right in the middle of excitement, he tries to create energy of Avalokiteshvara's compassion. And then he feels pretty good! So he asked, “Is that right?” I said, “Yes, or no.”

Well, in a sense it's pretty good, but in a sense it's nothing but a ghost depending on the trees and grasses: depending on the imagination of Avalokiteshvara, and "haunting" the excitement, spiritual fascination. If you are really stuck there even a moment, you just look at that experience; it's not the last word of peace. Peace and harmony is not something coming from outside, but from you. Not *from* you... *in* you. *You* are peace. You must be peace itself.

So even if you constantly practice like this, and even if you feel good because you can get the energy of compassion or you can get the energy of your life, it is still [an imaginary] world. Because it is nothing to do with real peace of you. Because you are still swayed away by imagination of energy, or spiritual fascination, or excitement... many things. Feeling good or not feeling bad, always. But real peace is you must be the last word of your being, *exactly*.

– From "Blue Cliff Record Case 51: Hsueh Feng's What Is It? – Talk 1" (January 11, 1984) at 51:32

The mind is sneaky: we can attach even to the concept of liberation and compassion. That makes Buddhism kind of hard. But it's also simple: just be right there.

This topic comes up a lot. In fact, it will come up again in the very next chapter.

Chapter 7: Playing in the Entranceway

Paragraph 2 Part 2

直饒誇會豐悟兮、獲瞥地之智通、得道明心兮、舉衝天之志氣、雖逍遙於入頭之邊量、幾虧闕於出身之活路。

Suppose you are confident in your understanding and rich in enlightenment, gaining the wisdom that knows at a glance, attaining the Way and clarifying the mind, arousing an aspiration to reach for the heavens. You are playing in the entranceway, but you are still short of the vital path of emancipation. [SZ]

Suppose one gains pride of understanding and inflates one's own enlightenment, glimpsing the wisdom that runs through all things, attaining the Way and clarifying the mind, raising an aspiration to escalate the very sky. One is making the initial, partial excursions about the frontiers but is still somewhat deficient in the vital Way of total emancipation. [EB]

Commentary

Mahayana Buddhist teaching talks about the “vibration of the mind,” including the very subtlest vibrations. The basic issue is, this finest vibration never goes away. Katagiri Roshi says:

For instance, according to *The Awakening of Faith*: at the *tathāgata* stage, Buddha knows the finer of the fine vibration of the mind. Among the fine vibration of the mind, there is the *finest* vibration there; very minute vibration of the mind. Because mind is constantly moving. Even though you say *moment* – the *Abhidharmakosha* says the moment consists of 65 instances. If so, what is a moment, you know? So the moment is a very fine vibration of the mind, but still there is the finest vibration of the mind within the moment – that is at the 65th vibration of the mind. How can you touch it? You don't know what it is. But it's there. Through zazen you can notice this.

So, if you are engaged in a perfect state of concentration, let's [look at] your mind in *zazen*. Then you really feel exactly the planting into *samadhi*. But still you can see the very minute vibration of the mind, so-called "perfect concentration," "perfect state of planting into *samadhi*." You can see: "Oh, I am planting into the perfect *samadhi* now." Something like this is the very minute vibration of the mind by which you can realize what you are doing, what is mind.

But no matter how long you recognize this minute movement, vibration of the mind, you never be free from vibration. No; because even though you say, "I am perfectly calm now" – that is already vibration. [*He laughs.*] So "thinking not thinking" begets thinking. Realization of the perfect *samadhi* begets vibration of the mind. So you are never free from vibrations.

That's the issue. But if we stopped there, it might be a bit of a downer. Katagiri Roshi continues:

So how do you be free from this very minute vibration of the mind, from moment to moment? It's very difficult to say *how* you do it. No, we don't know. But this is the *tathāgata* stage, according to *The Awakening of Faith*. It is true! So finally, that is the place [where] the one world, where the very minute vibration of the mind can be realized: by buddha-*tathāgata*. At that time, buddha-*tathāgata* knows how to live there.

Because whatever you think, no matter how long you cognize or you realize that very minute vibration of the mind, you never stop vibrating your mind. So how do you stop vibrating your mind? This is, it's very simple, *very* simple. It's very simple, but it's too simple to know. [*He laughs.*] So all you have to do is just *be there*.

Just be. *Tathāgata* stops vibrating. "*Tathāgata* knows how to stop vibrating" means just *be* exactly – with no second person, no second thought. This is total dynamic working. You become exactly one.

– From "Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith" (March 22, 1986)

So, you can do it – or *tathāgata* can do it. What you can't do is attach to it. It's not something that "you" get to "have."

Katagiri Roshi discusses “raising an aspiration to escalate the very skies” when he gives the talk on *shō*, “realization,” which we referred to in Chapter 3:

So that is the place where all living beings coexist in peace, and ... synchronize with each other in peace and harmony. That is *shō*, “realization.”

So that *shō*, the consummation of being, is not [something] you try to manifest. No, you cannot do it, because this is exactly the *ultimate* state of existence. You don't know [it]. But the unique way is to let it manifest by virtue of making your water clear or calm. Or, practically speaking, you really devote yourself to do something thoroughly, with sincere heart, *exactly* do it: then, the consummation of being comes out, emerges from [that] naturally. That is our practice.

But we always try to get that truth or consummation of being. We try to get it. That's why we say, “By practice, let's attain enlightenment.” That makes you *more* confused. It's pretty hard to get such enlightenment. Of course you can attain enlightenment, but that enlightenment is the first or second enlightenment I mentioned: *kaku* or *satori*. Still *kaku* and *satori* are nothing but a human experience, limited by individualities. So it's not universal. Universal enlightenment is the state of being free from individual experience called *kaku*, awakening, or *satori*. According to Buddha's term, it is called *nirvana*. Nirvana. So *nirvana* corresponds to *shō*: proof, or verification.

So *nirvana* is a place where all kinds of experience of highest spiritual life are melted into. That is called nirvana. In other words, all kinds of the highest level of spiritual life is liberated. And then it is called *nirvana*. That is called *total liberation*.

So that's why ... even though you don't experience this *shō*, the actualizing the consummation of being, even though you don't experience the ultimate nature of existence... as best as we can, we try to approach it, we try to come near to it. In many ways – psychologically, intellectually – in many ways we try [to] see even a dim image. As close as you can, you try to approach. That is our study.

And then, [...] to touch directly the ultimate nature of [your self] is your responsibility, your business. Your responsibility, so-called ... flow of activities – when you are exactly in the continuous flow of activities, and then you are there, exactly. [But] consciousness always slips off this flow

of activities, and analyzes, synthesizes, so that's why it's pretty hard to touch directly.

So that's [where] in *Fukanzazengi*, [...] Dōgen Zenji [says],

Suppose one gains pride of understanding and influences one's own enlightenment...

So, by zazen, you can attain awakening and enlightenment, *satori*, and then you are proud of yourself. Then he says, that's fine, but:

Suppose you gain pride of understanding and influence your own enlightenment, glimpsing the wisdom that runs through all things, attaining the way and clarifying the mind, raising an aspiration to escalate the very sky.

[*He laughs.*] Do you understand? That always happens in the religious world. Always you really go up to the sky, pretty high. And then you completely forget to come down to earth. [*Laughter.*] But the more you try to stay high in the sky, impermanence ... lets you fall down to the earth, and then at that time you hurt so much. [*He laughs.*] Because you are too high to come down, so you hurt so much.

Just like a helicopter, you know? [*Laughter.*] Each person is flying a helicopter, with three propellers: [...] *suffering* and *karma* and also *self-centeredness*. The three propellers run pretty fast, and then finally, everyone can fly in the sky. Each person can fly, and then he likes it, you know? Because he [doesn't bother himself], he always keeps himself in peace and harmony, keeping away from the people. So he tries to do many things as he likes; that's [what] everyone does in the sky, in the world. And then – they bump into each other, by chance. And then it hurts very much, you know? Sometimes one propeller is broken and then, boom, they fall to earth, and then it hurts so much. This is suffering; always we do [this].

That's why Dōgen Zenji says here,

... raising an aspiration to escalate the very skies. One is making the initial partial excursions about the frontiers, but is still somewhat deficient in the vital way of total emancipation.

So still a little far, a little far.

So, very naturally, the important point is [that] practice must be total manifestation of ultimate nature of existence, and ultimate nature of existence is simultaneously present with your practice. Because ultimate nature of existence is not your business. It is not something *you* try to manifest. No. You have to arrange circumstances, [arrange] your body and mind to be in peace and harmony, and then, ultimate nature of existence comes out naturally. Like the moon comes out from the clouds. Like this.

– From “*Bendōwa: Dōgen’s Questions & Answers – Talk 5*” (March 15, 1987)

So by zazen you can attain awakening (*kaku*) or enlightenment (*satori*), but these are still temporary, limited experiences – and coming down from them can be a bumpy ride.

Later in the same talk Katagiri Roshi is asked whether *kaku* “awakening” and *satori* “enlightenment” are important.

Someone: Is there a progression between these stages? Awareness, enlightenment, verification: is there a progression, and are those stages of growth?

Someone: So you go through one first, *kaku* first, then *satori*, [...]

Katagiri Roshi: I think so. Uh-huh.

I think *awakening* is used in English textbooks in many ways. But generally speaking, *awakening* is the first experience of spiritual life through the six senses. Okay? And then enlightenment, *satori*, is a little deeper than awakening, penetrating. You have to experience *satori* [...] through the body and mind. But awakening kind of comes through the consciousness; then you can awake. So *awakening* occurs in the conscious level, but *satori* occurs in the conscious and also physical levels, both. So a little deeper.

Question: But... there’s *shō*, even if you don’t experience *kaku* or *satori*, isn’t there?

Katagiri Roshi: Yeah, *kaku* and *satori*...

Question: How important are they?

Katagiri Roshi: *Kaku* and *satori*?

Question: Yeah.

Katagiri Roshi: Well, important. But people really try to hold on [to] *kaku* and *satori*, which seem to be a best experience. That's why Dōgen Zenji [says] that's why people are proud of themselves very much. They are proud of their understanding, their own experience, but this is nothing but escalating for the sky. [He laughs.] Going up to the sky, that's it. That's why under the beautiful flag of religions, we are always fighting. If you experience God, then you are proud of your experience and understanding of God, and then we become really high. That is really a problem for us. Finally, fighting.

So [the] most important point is, you must be liberated from that pride of your understanding of God, and Buddha, or enlightenment, or whatever. And then, you really become humble. You know? And also majestic. Very majestic and humble. And then you can help people. Otherwise, you create problems. That's what Dōgen Zenji says here.

So I don't mean *satori* and awakening are not important. They are very important for us.

Questioner: So, [...] *shō* was somehow always there.

Katagiri Roshi: Always there!

Questioner: It's always present, while *satori* or awakening are not necessarily always there.

Katagiri Roshi: *Satori* and awakening are kind of bubbles coming up, you know?

Questioner: Yes, [...] to experience it is important. But is it possible to realize [or] experience *shō* fully if you haven't experienced *satori* first?

Katagiri Roshi: I don't know which comes first. I think first, basically, *shō* is there, from the beginning to end, always. And then, under the certain circumstances, you can call it *awakening* sometimes, you can call it *satori* sometimes. Sometimes you cannot call it at all. That is *shō*. No name there, but you feel strong, on the basis of your life. You don't know what it is, but you feel strength.

Questioner: So are you saying that *satori* or awakening is not really necessary if you... ?

Katagiri Roshi: Well, it's necessary, but I don't think you should try to hold [them] always, try to get a hold. No. But you shouldn't ignore the *satori* and awakening. The point is you have to focus on that point, *shō*, where we are. Because we live there. So [focus on] where we are, and then we should take care of our life.

But usually, we always try to live in the realm of awakening or *satori*, and *then* we try to take care of human life. That's why [we are] more confused there. But we should focus on the very basic foundation, there, and then you can deal with *satori*, awakening, and many things. That's [what] Dōgen Zenji tries to present always. But this is not Dōgen's teaching, this is a general Buddhist teaching. [It's] why Nāgārjuna mentions 18 emptinesses, you know? [*He laughs.*] Why he has to say 18 emptinesses, 25 emptinesses, constantly. It's ridiculous! [*He laughs.*] But he has to say [it].

Someone: Excuse me, Roshi. Could you clarify what the difference is when you say this is a Buddhist view versus this is Dōgen's view?

Katagiri Roshi: Well, Dōgen's view is a more practical point. He gives suggestions how to practice it, how to [make] Buddha's teaching alive in human life, practically. That's always what Dōgen Zenji [talks about]. So he has very deep thought, [...] and his practice is backed by this deep thought – that's why people say Sōtō Zen's [or] Dōgen's philosophy [is] "scholastic." I don't think he is "scholastic." [*He laughs.*] He is a pretty religious, genuine person.

So he always puts it into practice, and then be free from thought, because deep thought is always working in his life as a religious life. So that's why his practice is very deep. But on the other hand, it's really manifested, so it's just like everyday practice.

– From "*Bendōwa: Dōgen's Questions & Answers – Talk 5*" (March 15, 1987) at 33:02

A danger here is that even when we realize that awakening and enlightenment are temporary, we can still attach to realization or *shō* as just another concept, and we can use it to criticize ourselves or others. Katagiri Roshi talks about this in one of his talks on *Genjōkōan*, with a special caution for priests:

Question: Hojo-san, when you're mentioning that when you're behaving morally and ethically you say "I'm a very good boy," "good saint" and so forth, and then that's ego – at the moment that you realize that that's ego coming in, is that *manas*?

Katagiri Roshi: Yes, ego.

Questioner: Realizing that it's ego (is ego)?

Katagiri Roshi: Yes; ego is *still* working there! Even though you do zazen and are constantly seeing and feeling who you are, how ego is working very deeply, still ego is working. So that's why very naturally pride is coming up; it's very difficult to be patient, or it's very difficult to be humble. Always there is ego. Even if you see the truth, [...] you attach to it even more, because it's very beneficial to you. Ego consciousness realizes how beneficial realization of *ālayavijñāna* is, and then *attaches* to it. [*He laughs.*] And then *manas* brings that attachment into the six consciousness world.

And then, at that time, *manas* really forces you to get everyone to believe something you have. That's why, if you believe something religiously, you're always forcing people, in many ways: "You should believe *this*; if you don't, you are stupid." [*He laughs.*]

Always [this is going on]; not only the religious world. [But] if you deal with religion, it's very dangerous, because you don't realize how hurt people [can be] through this ego. In the usual [world], it's very quick, and everyone expresses ego – that's why you don't feel how much you hurt people, because *everyone* does it, you know? [We say,] "You should express your ego; if you have a capability, you should express it." If you don't feel good: scream, scream. Everyone screams, so the whole room is screaming. Even if only one person screams, everyone says, "Oh, you're screaming." So your screaming doesn't hurt so much, because everyone does it. [*He laughs.*]

The religious world is more complicated. [*He laughs.*] If you see the religious world, so-called peace and harmony, through *belief*, then you attach strongly. And also the problem is that no one [else] experiences it; everyone behaves in a different way from you. That's why you strongly believe the truth after practicing hard for many, many years, and then you really attach to your experience, or career, and belief; then finally you put everyone down, because everyone is doing it in a completely different

way. So very naturally, if you want to save people, help people, you *force* them. If people don't follow it, you fight. That always happens. It's very dangerous. Spiritual fighting is really *miserable*.

So that's why we have to realize ego consciousness through meditation, and then you can feel directly who you are. And then, *manas*, ego consciousness, has *ālayavijñāna* as [its] object, which means you feel karmic life through realization of *manas*. You can see.

How can you take care of your life? Sometimes, there is no way. Katagiri is Katagiri; no matter how long I study Buddhism, still [there is some] smell; I can't escape it. But, this is Katagiri's; this is a [way] for Katagiri. [*He laughs.*] But I don't [mean] it is a goal, what I have to do. Next, I have to go farther, deeper, until realizing *ālayavijñāna* as *tathāgatagarbha*. That means completely you have to touch the base of *manas*. You should directly experience stream energy. Directly, okay? In other words, you must be *on there*; you must be right there. Instead of understanding through conceptualization – no. Consciously or unconsciously you always understand in a conceptualized [way], but it is not the experience of *ālayavijñāna*. You have to directly be right there, beyond the world of conceptualization.

Where you should be present is right there. That is the stream of energy, the flow of energy. And then, at that time, this is really *cosmic*. So wherever you may be, all you have to do is just be there, and go. But that is nothing to hurt anything, because in that realm of the world, all sentient beings are included. So [there is] nothing to hurt; if you hurt something, you fall away from it.

So that is the bodhisattva category and buddhas category [that] you should learn. This is the advantage of practice for human beings.

[...] If you are a priest, you should taste and chew and digest what I told you today again and again. And then read this *Genjōkōan*; then you can really feel the spirit.

One more thing. Usually people say, "You should attain enlightenment. You should be aware. If you're not aware, if you don't realize, if you don't attain enlightenment, you are not Buddhist; you are a stupid guy." [*Laughter*] That is not the Buddhistic way; no. It's a complete misunderstanding. Alright?

So, please [try to] understand what I have said today again and again. And then, if you understand what I said: [...] even if you attain enlightenment, originally where [are you]? “Originally” means very basically, profoundly, where [are you] standing? Are you standing in the realm of six consciousnesses, or seventh consciousness? Yes, you are... but simultaneously, the very source of your presence is *ālayavijñāna*, *tathāgatagarbha*. What is that? That is just the flow of energies, which is very pure and clear. So that is called *you are Buddha*, where all sentient beings exist just like that.

We should learn that, okay? Basically, profoundly, you are already present there; that’s why even if you attain enlightenment, still there is opportunity or possibility to manifest this. So *how*? That’s why I say, finally, when you do gassho, please do gassho. That’s it!

Dōgen Zenji says from the beginning [it is] just like this. It’s a little bit difficult to understand; that’s why you should digest what I said again and again. Then, if you get into this *Genjōkōan*, it’s a little bit easier to understand.

– From “*Genjōkōan: Talk 2*” (June 6, 1987) at 47:12

Chapter 8: Buddha and Bodhidharma

Paragraph 3

矧彼祇園之爲生知兮、端坐六年之蹤跡可見。少林之傳心印兮、面壁九歲之聲名尚聞。古聖既然、今人盍辦。

Consider the Buddha: although he was wise at birth, the traces of his six years of upright sitting can yet be seen. As for Bodhidharma, although he had received the mind-seal, his nine years of facing a wall is celebrated still. If even the ancient sages were like this, how can we today dispense with wholehearted practice? [SZ]

Need I mention the Buddha, who was possessed of inborn knowledge? the influence of his six years of upright sitting is noticeable still. Or Bodhidharma's transmission of the mind-seal?—the fame of his nine years of wall-sitting is celebrated to this day. Since this was the case with the saints of old, how can men of today dispense with negotiation of the Way? [EB]

Commentary

Why was the Buddha “wise at birth,” having “inborn knowledge”? Perhaps it's something like what Katagiri Roshi spoke about on Buddha's Birthday:

... you know in the [story], when the Buddha was born – do you remember? The Buddha walks seven steps, saying, “I alone am the [...] honored one in heaven and on earth.”

He walks seven steps. Why does he walk seven steps? This is also a legend.

The number seven is a holy number, according to *Rigveda*. In India, *Rigveda* is a very old Indian philosophy. If you study Indian philosophy, you have to read the *Rigveda*. It's very wonderful... I forget the name, but it's very nice in Indian philosophy. In the *Rigveda*, I think the seven holy men command great respect from the people in the scripture, and then from that point the number seven becomes a holy number. So that comes into the Buddhist tradition: so-called the seven past buddhas, before the Buddha was born, who were the Buddha's teachers.

So we say [there were] seven buddhas in the past, before Buddha was born, because even though we don't have any historical proof [or] historical references, as long as Buddha was born here in this world, I think there had to be the past. In other words, as long as you exist today in the present, I think you should have a past. If you see the present, the present brings on the past and also the future, and *then* you can see the present. Through the present you can see the past, you can see the future; in other words, we may reverse the order and say the present is supported by the past and future. So if you accept Buddha's existence, very naturally he has a past. That is the seven buddhas before Buddha was born.

So that's why seven is a holy number, [and] that's why we say in the legend the Buddha walks seven steps. Why does he walk seven steps? Because people believe that he is a human but he is not human, [he is] something more than human, who is great, beyond human speculation. That's probably why he walked the seven steps the moment when he was born. It's impossible for us as humans, but he is [both] a human but he's not human, because he is *great*. Can you see [this]?

Well, this is natural, from human feeling. For instance, if you become *great*, more than usual people, people really believe [in] you. Even though you move your hand in the same way as people do, your moving is special. Do you understand? [*He laughs.*] Katagiri smiles, and Katagiri smiles in the same way as you smile, but if you really believe him, trust him, and pay homage to him, exactly his smile is completely special. And from that smile, you know, the light [comes] forth. [*He laughs.*] Do you understand that human feeling? Yes, it is natural! But if you don't [exactly] trust some person, even though he smiles in the same way as people do, you hate it, you hate his smile. But his smile is the same thing! [*He laughs.*]

So, that's why he walks seven steps. Seven is a holy number. Anyway, he walks from the [mother's] belly. [That] means he is something special: walking in the human world, walking hand in hand with all sentient beings, [even as a] baby.

And also he says, "I alone am [the] honored one [in heaven and on earth]." This is not individualism, okay? This is not egoism. It [does not mean] egoism; it is the implication of thoughtfulness, kindness, or compassion to *all*, because *all* are great, completely great. No one hurts or destroys that greatness [inherent] in everyone and all things – trees, birds, nature,

pebbles, waters, et cetera. Everything has greatness, [the] so-called *life-line of buddha*. Exactly the same lifeline [that] Buddha Shakyamuni has.

That's why this is called – maybe in the usual terms we say [a] *human right*. [If we] say [a] *human right*, it is a very usual word, but religiously we are *great*, beyond human speculation, human judgement. That's why we have to respect [others], or we have to put ourselves in others' place, and be thoughtful, be kind, be compassionate to human beings, and also to everything.

– From “Buddha's Birthday” (April 13, 1986) at 10:16.

But even with that inherent greatness (which everyone has), “the traces of his six years of upright sitting can yet be seen.” Even though we can't attach to any result from practice-realization, those results do appear. There is a kind of maturation that happens naturally in practice.

Katagiri Roshi talks about maturing or deepening our life in most of his talks. Here is one example:

The other day I told you, when you want to be great mountaineer, you have to be one with the mountains. How can you do it? Just climb; climb the mountain. Every day; even in the snow. In winter and summer, we have to be one with, be present with the mountains.

To be present, be one with the mountain is to make your life deepen and mature. If your life is mature, very naturally you can live with the mountain exactly in the same way as the mountain's life. So, mountains give your maturity to you.

How can you know? You try to climb the mountain constantly.

Well, whatever you do, this is a very basic practice for us.

– From “Blue Cliff Record Case 51: Hsueh Feng's What Is It? – Talk 2” (January 18, 1984) at 33:16.

Katagiri Roshi often talks about the ripening of the persimmon. Here he is talking about Chao Chou (Jōshū), who was himself a semi-legendary figure in Zen:

Maybe you can understand the progress of human life in terms of three points. One point, the first stage, is fruit. Second, the ripeness of fruit. [Third], the perfect ripeness of fruit.

For instance, a beautiful persimmon on a tree – that is a fruit. That is awareness of buddha-nature, or awareness of how important human life is, how sublime human life is. So you respect yourself, you respect others. That is the first stage. That is a fruit.

And then, gradually this persimmon is getting ripe. So, pretty sweet. Not *exactly* sweet, not *exactly* ripe, but it's ripe. That is the second stage. When you study hard and practice hard, then your personality, your human life is getting ripe. And then [you are] understanding people pretty well, and also yourself.

And the third stage: when the persimmon is completely ripe on the branch, very naturally that persimmon falls down to the ground, and the guts of the persimmon come out. Do you understand that one? [*He chuckles.*]

That's pretty nice. "Guts come out" means whatever it is, whatever you want, everything comes out, but it [isn't] against any rule and the reason of nature, and [it is] exactly going smoothly. That means *egolessness*. According to egolessness everything comes out. So, perfect maturity of human personality.

That is the three stages.

So, the ripeness of the fruit is not good enough. Because, for instance, finishing high school or university, and getting the degrees, [like] doctorate degrees – it's *ripe*, but it's not ripe *exactly*. After that you have to polish yourself again and again. And then, maybe [...] you can let your life mature and ripen, so then you become a great medical doctor et cetera as a human being, because you can help.

But it's not good enough. So, you have to make your life *more* mature – until the mature fruit falls down to the ground and all the guts come out. That means your personality is not only working in your territory, so-called [field of] medicine, or psychology, or music – but also, when your maturity is perfected, completed, at that time your mature personality is working everywhere, even in daily routine, even out of your music area

or psychological area as a professional. Wherever you may go, your life is really working smoothly.

That is called *freedom, emancipation*. Or *maturity*. Or *adept*.

I think Chao Chou in this koan is really mature and perfect ripeness of fruit. Everything is going pretty smoothly, naturally. So nothing sharp in the words. He uses words, but those words are not very sharp. Priests' words come up very naturally, smoothly. But lots of information is there, instruction is there.

– From “Blue Cliff Record Case 52: Chao Chou Lets Asses Cross, Lets Horses Cross – Talk 1” (January 21, 1984).

So when we reach a certain stage of maturity – perfect ripeness of the persimmon – we can stop, right?

No. Katagiri Roshi says:

So we have a karmic life. Everyone is different; everyone is characterized by karmic life of their own. But it is not *wrong*, it is not *right*. Sometimes we really respect a person who [renounces] his or her own karmic life; then we really respect them as a “saint.” I don't think it is right. I don't think it is wrong; it's fine. But Buddhism doesn't say karmic life is wrong, karmic life is right; no. The point is we should constantly *deepen* karmic life, because karmic life is Buddha.

And then we say, “Karmic life [is] Buddha, so why don't you accept karmic life?” No. If you say so, you stay on the chair of buddha. So you never have a chance to deepen the stage of the buddha. Buddha is not a *stage*, buddha is constantly great energies to encourage you to deepen, to taste your life. And then, you can create *total, whole personality*, from which you can really educate, nurture you and everyone.

[...] So we should respect [great capacity], but I don't think we should be proud of ourselves, “I am great.” At that time, you know, the deepening of your life *stops*. You stop deepening your life, deepening the experience.

That's why the more you become a master of something, the more you continue practicing. You can see people like this: the more they become a famous pianist or dancer, the more they're always practicing, because

there is no reason why they have to stay at a certain stage, and showing [that they are] proud of their life. No way; constantly deepening his or her experience of dancer, music, et cetera.

– From “Platform Sutra – Talk 7” (April 24, 1987) at 33:00

But surely a Zen teacher is different from those examples?

Uh, no. You cannot say that the teacher is always having the Zen exactness and wonderful zazen. No. Even the teacher has to take care of zazen from moment to moment, as you do. Exactly the same. There is no sign of priding yourself as a master, as a teacher. *No way*. Because, even for the teacher, there is a mind, there is a body, there is breath, and environment, and sensory world.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 2” (June 10, 1979) at 1:27:20.

And also, this kind of maturation does not happen alone. Here we again see the connection between zazen and the Precepts:

[Kyōgō Zen master says,] “In attaining enlightenment under Bodhi tree Shakyamuni Buddha fruited the precepts.” Shakyamuni Buddha did not try to fruit the precepts; *fruit* is [that] naturally something is matured, nurtured. Not only by one person; no, you cannot mature anything [that way], you cannot ripen anything by yourself. You need lots of help. You know, others: trees, birds, all sentient beings, past, present, future. All sentient beings [are there], *then* something is ripened.

You can see the fruit on the tree. You say, “Oh, fruit!” No one pays attention to the depth of the fruit’s life, how fruit becomes fruit; we don’t pay attention to it. And then immediately we pick it up and eat it. That is really a hungry ghost attitude, you know? *[There are some chuckles.]*

That is important: A precept is not something produced or created by somebody or something. Realization of the whole universe, how it is going: fruit ripens. The person’s life, tree’s life, and all sentient beings, that is called *precept*, we say. First, you should remember this [point].

– From “The Way of Precept Practice: Restraint and Extermination” (August 13, 1988)

Bodhidharma was the First Ancestor in China, the prototypical Zen Master. This is how Katagiri Roshi tells the story on one of many occasions:

When Bodhidharma went to China to teach Buddhism, first of all he met Emperor Wu. Emperor Wu asked Bodhidharma, “I have built lots of Buddhist temples and educated Buddhist monks and nuns. What is the merit?” And Bodhidharma said, “No merit.”

Emperor Wu didn't understand *no merit*, so he continued to [wonder], “If Buddhist teaching is no merit, why do we study Buddhist teaching?” It didn't make sense to Emperor Wu, so he asked, “What is the essence of Buddha's teaching?” Bodhidharma said, “Vastness; nothing.” The vastness of no holiness, and the vastness of nothing.

This statement was very impressive, so although [Emperor Wu] didn't understand, he felt something. So he continued [to ask]: “If there is nothing, and the essence of Buddhism is vastness of existence – if so, who are you?” Who is this little guy in front of Emperor Wu? And Bodhidharma said, “I don't know.” Because even Bodhidharma is completely nothing holy, just vastness of existence.

That *I don't know* is not the usual meaning of “I don't know” that you think. That *I don't know* is that he knows pretty well, but still Buddha's teaching is completely beyond the intellectual sense or intellectual explanation.

So that is a very simple statement: “Nothing holy; just vastness.” But this is a very impressive statement. So from generation to generation, we still have to continue to think about this. It has been handed down from generation to generation because it is not merely words, it comes from Bodhidharma's true heart. He really touches the core of existence.

The core of existence is really silent – but pretty active. It's very vast, because it is always embracing the whole thing. But according to human speculation, we think that is kind of contradictory, because [existence is] embracing everything in peace and harmony. So that's why it's vast, nothing holy; no discrimination there.

– From “*Blue Cliff Record Case 43: Tung Shan’s No Cold or Heat, Talk 1*” (March 16, 1983)

This is what Bodhidharma came to China to transmit.

After his meeting with Emperor Wu, legend says that Bodhidharma travelled to the north and sat “facing the wall” for nine years. People often have the idea that Bodhidharma’s nine years of “facing the wall” was about making a point, or the pursuit of some new level of enlightenment. But what if it was about practice for its own sake?

Question: You brought up the story about Bodhidharma sitting and facing the wall for nine years. And I was talking to someone about this recently, and this person told me that the reason that Bodhidharma went and faced the wall for ten years was because Emperor Wu didn’t understand what he was saying so he banished him.

Katagiri Roshi: *[Laughs.]*

Questioner: And I always thought that Bodhidharma chose to go and face the wall for nine years to sort of make a point. What’s your understanding about why he went?

Katagiri Roshi: *[Still laughing.]* Well, that is a story; human beings try to understand the stories, you know? So everyone understands in a different way from that same story. But the point is, I think Bodhidharma sitting for nine years at Shaolin Temple is to manifest his life and the Buddha’s teaching.

Questioner: Okay, that’s it.

Katagiri Roshi: That’s it. Wherever he may go.

For instance, when I come to the United States, on the surface there are many different changes: I used to be in Los Angeles, San Francisco, and [now] here in Minneapolis. But strictly speaking, I’m always sitting and facing the wall. Nothing to teach you, actually. That’s all I have to do. And also, you have nothing to get from me. You’re always sitting facing the wall and being in the location I mentioned (where everything intersects). [...] Day to day, you have to take care of [life] in terms of that location, and then many, many different worlds are coming up, you know? San Francisco

and Minneapolis. And then each time we have to take care of different pictures, but basically you have to be in the same location always. That is sitting for nine years; that's the meaning of Bodhidharma sitting.

And we sit facing the wall to this day. But here is some more information about what "facing the wall" actually means:

In *zazen* we practice facing the wall. Bodhidharma [talks about] "wall meditation." Wall meditation means facing the wall, [...] observation of the wall, looking at the wall. "Looking at the wall" doesn't mean *you* look at the wall, okay? The wall is *emptiness*. The wall is the source of existence; [there is nothing] there.

So doing *zazen*, facing the wall, means abiding firmly in *zazen*, right-now-right-here – and then, what can you experience? This is *emptiness*. Nothing. But *nothing* doesn't mean nothing, because simultaneously [...] you can touch very deeply the source of the human phenomenal world. That's why in the *Nirvana Sutra* [it says], "If you want to see suchness, the truth of the human world, you have to see it through meditation, *zazen*." That's why doing *zazen* is very important for us.

– From "Mindfulness – Talk 1" (March 21, 1984) at 1-26:16

Katagiri Roshi says that as part of facing the wall we must practice *deep faith*:

Basically, first we have to establish a deep faith that all sentient beings have the-same-and-one-nature. And second, we have to establish a state of the mind that is like a wall, so-called emptiness. So that's why you always [sit] "facing the wall." The wall is [emptiness].

So first you have to have a very deep faith, that all sentient beings have the-same-and-one-nature. Whatever happens, whether you like or don't like it, beyond this, everything exists just like that. That is a very deep faith. *Deep faith* means your life must stand up straight there. *How?* That is second. You have to establish the state of your mind that is like a wall, so-called emptiness. In other words, abiding firmly in a state non-dualistic understanding.

– From "Mindfulness – Talk 3" (March 23, 1984) at 1-36:20

We will discuss this kind of faith more in the next chapter, Chapter 9: “Take the Backward Step.”

Katagiri Roshi comments on a line from a verse in *The Blue Cliff Record*:

Even Yellow Head (Buddha) and Blue Eyes (Bodhidharma) have yet to discern.

Well, even Buddha Shakyamuni or Bodhidharma cannot understand it, cannot *know* what it is. But anyway Bodhidharma and Buddha Shakyamuni – or ancestors, your parents, your grandparents – continued to dwell in the beautiful life force of nature constantly, making their life mature, instead of *knowing* or *analyzing* constantly. [That] is a *part* of human activity, but it's not all.

So, it is not something to realize or to know, but to dwell in and make your life deepen or mature. That means that, here it says, “even Yellow Head (Buddha) and Blue Eyes (Bodhidharma) have yet to discern.” It's not a matter of discussion. No. It is something you have to do.

– From “*Blue Cliff Record Case 51: Hsueh Feng's What Is It? – Talk 2*” (January 18, 1984) at 50:30

So, how can we today dispense with wholehearted practice?

In Chapters 1 through 8, we've looked at the first part of *Fukanzazengi*, where Dōgen Zenji more or less talks about *why* we do zazen. Of course, really we've been talking about what zazen *is* all along. But basically, we can say that in Chapters 9 through 11 we will now look at Dōgen Zenji's statement of *what* to do. And then in Chapters 12 through 25, we will look into details of *how* to do it.

Chapter 9: Take the Backward Step

Paragraph 4 Part 1

所以須休尋言逐語之解行、須學回光返照之退步。

Therefore, put aside the intellectual practice of investigating words and chasing phrases, and learn to take the backward step that turns the light and shines it inward. [SZ]

You should therefore cease from practice based on intellectual understanding, pursuing words and following after speech, and learn the backward step that turns your light inwardly to illuminate your self. [EB]

Commentary

The first part of *Fukanzazengi*, which we discussed in Chapters 1 through 8, discusses *the Way* and *practice-realization*. We could say that the first part is explaining *why* we do zazen. Having established that, next is a direct statement of *what* we should do:

You should therefore cease from practice based on intellectual understanding, pursuing words and following after speech, and learn the backward step that turns your light inwardly to illuminate your self. Body and mind of themselves will drop away, and your original face will be manifest. If you want to attain suchness, you should practice suchness without delay. [EB]

These three sentences are the subjects of Chapters 9, 10, and 11.

We discussed in Chapter 4 and elsewhere that the teaching of Buddhism goes beyond the practice of intellectual understanding. What's the alternative? We need to “learn to take the backward step that turns the light and shines it inward.”

“Turn the light and shine it inward” is *ekō henshō* (回光返照), a key term in Zen Buddhism. To do that, we “take the backward step.” However, translations of this line vary a great deal, as do opinions about what it actually means.

Katagiri Roshi says:

[...] “Learn the backward step” means, let’s return to that very inception of the moment. The very inception of time and space. The very inception of *gassho*, or *zazen*. In other words, just put yourself right in the midst of the inception of doing *zazen*, *gassho*, standing, et cetera. It means let’s go back to the original moment, the first moment. Again and again, again and again.

And then, if you *do it*, even for a moment, it “turns your light inwardly to illuminate yourself.” Very naturally you create a wholesome world, a peaceful, harmonious world, even [if] you don’t see it. This is [that] naturally it’s going.

So that’s why, if you continue to do it, naturally you will come to enhance or to deepen your life. Even though you don’t know how much your practice is progressing or not, it doesn’t matter. Sometimes you can see how much; sometimes you cannot see. *Most of* the time you don’t see how much your practice is making progress; no. But all you have to do is constantly go back to that source of being, existence.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986) at 44:03

If we’re expecting this line in *Fukanzazengi* to be a kind of special technique or trick to “do meditation,” what follows in this chapter may be surprising, perhaps even frustrating. Because to “take the backward step” is something simple, very simple. In fact, we already covered it, in Chapter 7, “Playing in the Entranceway”:

So how do you be free from this very minute vibration of the mind, from moment to moment? It’s very difficult to say *how* you do it. No, we don’t know. But this is the *tathāgata* stage, according to *The Awakening of Faith*. It is true! So finally, that is the place [where] the one world, where the very minute vibration of the mind can be realized: by buddha-*tathāgata*. At that time, buddha-*tathāgata* knows how to live there.

Because whatever you think, no matter how long you cognize or you realize that very minute vibration of the mind, you never stop vibrating your mind. So how do you stop vibrating your mind? This is, it’s very simple, *very* simple. It’s very simple, but it’s too simple to know. [*He laughs.*] So all you have to do is just *be there*.

Just be. *Tathāgata* stops vibrating. “*Tathāgata* knows how to stop vibrating” means just *be* exactly – with no second person, no second thought. This is total dynamic working. You become exactly one.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986)

If you got that – or maybe even if you didn’t get it – this is probably a good point to pause, stop reading for a while, and maybe do some actual zazen, before continuing.

In the same talk, Katagiri Roshi says much more to explain this, so we will go back to the beginning and cover some ground.

Katagiri Roshi’s teachings about “taking the backward step” take us in a direction we might not expect: understanding the nature of Buddhist *faith*, or *belief*.

Often in English translations of Buddhist texts, words with Western religious connotations are used where no such connotation is meant, which causes considerable confusion. For example, the word “defiled” means something very different in Buddhism (at least in Zen Buddhism) than how it is usually heard: in Buddhism, *defiled* means almost the same as “dualistic”; there is no moral implication, or at least far less of one. So one might justifiably wonder: “Is there a translation issue here?”

“Faith,” however, is an accurate translation of the Sanskrit word *śraddhā*, in Japanese *shin* (信). Still, we have to be careful how we understand this *faith*. Buddhist faith is not so much faith in a religious figure or a doctrine. Buddhist faith is faith in the Way: “Where all beings exist in peace and harmony, prior to the germination of any subtle ideas.” (See Chapter 2: “The Way.”)

What does that mean? Katagiri Roshi says:

Today I would like to talk about the key point of the practice in terms of *faith*.

In *Gakudō-yōjinshū*, “Points to Watch in Buddhist Training,” Number 9 (“The Need to Practice in Accordance with the Way”), Dōgen Zenji says:

To study the Way is to try to become one with it – to forget even a trace of enlightenment. Those who would practice the Way should first of all believe in it. Those who believe in the Way should believe that they have been in the Way from the

very beginning, subject to neither delusion, illusive thoughts, and confused ideas nor increase, decrease, and mistaken understanding. Engendering belief like this, clarify the Way and practice it accordingly – this is the essence of studying the Way.

(From *Zen Master Dōgen: An Introduction with Selected Writings*, translated by Yuho Yokoi with Daizen Victoria, page 57.)

So the essence of the practice, practicing the Way, is to believe that you are present right in the midst of the Way, “subject to neither delusion, illusive thoughts, and confused ideas nor increase, decrease, and mistaken understanding.” This is the first important point.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986)

This is called “belief” – but it’s not intellectual belief, or at least it’s not limited to intellectual belief. In fact it’s more or less the opposite of that: it’s precise oneness with what’s going on, “with no confusions, no perverted views, no increase or decrease, no misunderstanding.” Dōgen Zenji says, “Engendering belief like this, clarify the Way and practice it accordingly.”

Why do we need this belief? For at least two reasons. The first reason is that “to become one with the Way” – “to forget even a trace of enlightenment” – we cannot do that through the intellect. The only way is to put ourselves directly there, again and again. The only way we can do *that* is through something we can call “faith” or “belief” – because it’s something we are *doing*, enacting, right in the midst of whatever we are thinking or feeling about it.

This “putting ourselves directly there” is “taking the backward step.” So in this sense, taking the backward step is the application of faith.

Again, taking the backward step is to return to the very inception of the moment. Katagiri Roshi says:

So in the very inception of being, here and now – in other words, in the very inception of birth – [it] is completely [beyond] questions. But in that realm of the world, you are creating your life, constantly. That’s why everyone has a great capability to create a world, life.

Everyone has great capability to create the human world. Whichever [way] to go: bad, good, whichever. But if you realize that realm of the one world, [...] I think you cannot create an unwholesome world – because it is very

pure, and because you can see all sentient beings living in peace and harmony. [...] You cannot do something wrong, you cannot hurt anybody, so very naturally you create a peaceful world. That is so-called *creative* life *with* all sentient beings.

That is [why] first we have to *believe* [in ourselves, that we are] exactly present right in the midst of this Way.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986) at 15:16

Katagiri Roshi says much more about this in the talk, some of which we have already covered, for example in Chapter 5: “Free from Dust,” where we talked about karmic life not being separate from total dynamic working. But for now, we need to move on to Dōgen Zenji’s second point, where he says how we *get to* this faith.

Katagiri Roshi continues with Dōgen Zenji’s second important point in *Gakudō-yōjinshū*, “Points to Watch in Buddhist Training,” Number 9 (“The Need to Practice in Accordance with the Way”):

But next, in the process of reaching this one world – so-called *belief, faith* – Dōgen Zenji says there are two processes. One is, *cut off the root of discriminative thinking*. Second: *body and mind dropping off*.

This is our practice. This is [the process] to reach that belief, one world, [that] you are present right in the midst of the Way, without any delusions, confusions, perverted views, mistakes. How can we reach there? That is first, we have to cut off the root of discriminative thinking.

I mentioned the root of discriminative thinking is very minute vibration of the mind. This is called *root*, the root of the discriminating mind. We are *always* discriminating. Even though I am talking about this with wholeheartedness, still I am discriminating! Right in the middle of talking, I am talking to myself simultaneously as I am talking to you: “Hey, Katagiri... you are pretty good.” [*He laughs.*] At that time [this is] very minute vibration of the mind. Or if you dance on the stage, you are completely devoting yourself into dance, but still your very minute vibration of the mind is poking into that perfect state of the dancing – and then thinking, evaluating, discriminating. Do you understand what I mean? This is called *root*, root of discriminating mind.

So how can we reach [...] the oneness, so-called *faith*, Buddhist faith? To cut off that root means [you say], "Please... shut up. Just do it." [*He laughs.*] That's it. Don't you think so? "Please keep your mouth shut, do it." That's all we have to do.

For instance, I mentioned maybe before, a gentleman in Japan was interested in running a business, so he asked a Zen master, "I have a big problem, please help me." So the Zen master asked, "What's that?" And then [the gentleman] said, "I am very interested in running a business." Well, whatever kind of business, business is all right. But he was interested in running a business, and the teacher said, "Oh, that's interesting. Please do it." But the gentleman said, "I don't have any money." And then the Zen master said, "If you don't have money, how can you run a business?" You cannot run a business, so stop and forget it. You know, stop running the business! [*He laughs.*] Stop thinking of running the business. [But the gentleman] says, "That is my problem, because that's why I want to run a business." And then the Zen master says, "How can I help you? That's *your* business, not my business." [*He laughs, and a couple people laugh.*]

Is that clear for you? That is *cut off the root of discriminating mind*. Not ignoring discriminating mind. We are always doing [something] like this. "I want to do zazen, but I don't want to have physical pain, et cetera. And I want to sleep in bed until 10 o'clock. So I want to do zazen, I want to deepen my life, et cetera; I want to be happy. But I don't want to do zazen getting up in the morning!" [*He laughs.*] That is your problem. How can I help you? I don't know; that's your business! [*He laughs.*] Do you understand?

That's why, if you want to reach *tathāgata* stage, all you can do is, "Please keep your mouth shut. Just do it." That's all you can do.

But students are always depending on the teaching: "Please help me." Well, yes, I can help you. But you should know that there is something in the realm of vibrating your mind very minutely – at that time there is nothing for me to do. So all you have to do is you just be in the *tathāgata* stage. That's it. How? Cut off the root of the discriminating mind.

You want to keep smoking? Yes, you want to, but it's not good for you; the cigarette case always says it's not good for your health. So you don't want to keep smoking, but you cannot stop it. So [you say,] "This is my problem, please help me." How can I help? That is always what we do.

So this is the best way, very simple, and *you* have to do it. I can help, and also ancestors and buddhas can help. But this is [that] the ancestors and buddhas always back you up; they are always behind you, encouraging you. Finally what you have to do is to do it *by yourself*.

So this is the first point: you have [...] to reach that faith. Believing in yourself right in the midst of the Way, which is completely peaceful, harmonious – with all sentient beings. You should trust in *you* like this, and believe in *you* like this.

[...] How can we do it? How can we reach there? That is the practice. First, cut off delusion, the root of discriminating mind. And then very naturally, secondly, Dōgen Zenji says, body and mind [are] dropping off. [...] This is called *total realization*. If you cut off the root of discriminating mind, put yourself right there, and then you can see the whole situation of the Twin Cities [as] if you are on the top of the IDS tower.

But we always have a problem: I want to see the state of the whole situation of the Twin Cities area, but I don't want to go [to the top of the IDS tower], you know? You want to see, but you don't want to go. So how can I help? Nothing. So all you have to do is: go. That's it.

So that is, if you put your body *right there*, then you can drop off your body and mind, you can be free from the root of discriminating mind. That means you can be exactly one with the very minute vibration of the mind. And then, no concept of the minute vibration of the mind.

So constantly you put your body and mind right in the middle of the very minute vibration of the mind, there. This is a very important practice. Constantly you have put your body there, put your body there, next moment, next moment, again and again.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986) at 25:23

People may have a reaction to hearing “please shut up.” In the next talk, there is a question about this:

Question: Hojo-san? Taking the backward step, it's like saying, “please shut up”?

Katagiri Roshi: [*Chuckles.*] Uh-huh.

[*Laughter.*]

You don't like it? [*He chuckles.*]

Well, even if you don't like it, that is a final thing you can do; a unique, final thing you can do... after struggling for a long time. [*He laughs.*]

So that is a unique way to allow you to exist fully.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 5: Direct Transmission” (March 23, 1986) at 1:03:30

This is the other reason why we need faith: because no-one can do this practice for us. Teachers can show and encourage us, buddhas and bodhisattvas support us, but the only person who can do *your* practice is *you*. So we have to have faith in ourselves: faith that we are already a “container” of the dharma, so we are completely qualified to do this practice. *Faith* is the motive power to actually do the practice.

But, to be clear, this is not saying to “shut up” forever. It means when you do zazen, *do* zazen. It's not about attaching to silence. In another talk, Katagiri Roshi says:

So, life and death is complete vastness, nothing to comment, nothing to say – but, there is the place you have to apply your effort. So-called, you have to say something about it.

Okay? It's kind of contradictory.

– From “Blue Cliff Record Case 55: Tao Wu's Condolence Call, Talk 3” (April 11, 1984).

Katagiri Roshi continues:

Anyway, let's go back, let's go back, every day. And then that is called *the backward step*. [It is] not “withdraw.”

That is called *reflection*.

Interestingly, Katagiri Roshi calls the backward step “reflection.” This seems to mean looking deeply at discriminating mind in order to cut off discriminating mind. Why is this interesting? Because, in Buddhist terms, the movement of discriminating mind is *suffering*.

Suffering (Pali: *dukkha*) is another deep topic in Buddhism. Katagiri Roshi goes into detail introducing “reflection,” “suffering,” and its root in “ignorance” (Sanskrit: *avidyā*, another key term in Buddhism) in “Principles of Practice, Talk 3: High Resolve” (March 21, 1986). Here, we need to stay focused on the backward step. But we should be prepared, once again, for the Zen understanding of these terms to be different from what we might be expecting.

In saying that the backward step is reflection, Katagiri Roshi is saying that our practice, constantly going back to the source of being, involves suffering:

[...] This reflection is [and] begets suffering; [it's] really suffering. But that suffering is completely beyond your intellectual understanding; [it's] before your intellect is suffering. Because everyone has to go back to there: consciously or unconsciously, the root of your being is coming from that realm. So very naturally, everyone always goes back to there, consciously or unconsciously.

But most people don't realize it! Even though they are standing there, they don't realize it. But they are very interested in the world *after*: the second moment, second thought, third thought. That is the so-called *samsaric world*. That's why the problem is going on and on; there is no peace. The more they try to get the peace, the more they beget not-peace in order to get the peace. That is *samsara*.

That's why if you want to be peaceful, please go back to the source of the first moment of the peace you have thought. Let's go back. This is the backward step. The backward step is not escaping from. Anyway, let's go back to that first moment of peace you have thought.

In other words, cutting off the root of discriminating mind, be peace *right now*. Right now, with your whole body and mind. And that is immediately you create peace, peaceful world.

But it is [an] event which occurs just in a moment, so you don't see it. That's why very naturally according to your intellectual sense, you can see “no hit” among a hundred thousand attempts to try to hit the bullseye. Nothing. That's why we need the encouragement – “please, follow like this” – [which] Dōgen mentions.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986) at 44:03

We need encouragement because looking deeply at suffering involves... well, suffering.

To explain further, Katagiri Roshi again turns to Avalokiteshvara:

That is called *reflection*. And also Dōgen Zenji mentions in this book – Number Six (“Advice for the Practice of Zen”), page 53, the second paragraph from the bottom:

The Buddha Sakyamuni said, “Turning the sound-perceiving stream of the mind inward, forsake knowing and being known.”

(From *Zen Master Dōgen: An Introduction with Selected Writings*, translated by Yuho Yokoi with Daizen Victoria.)

This is cutting off the root of discriminating mind, so-called reflection. “Learn the backward step, and turn your light inwardly to illuminate yourself.” How do you do this? This is “Avalokiteshvara turns the sound-perceiving.”

Avalokiteshvara is a bodhisattva who listens to the sound of perfect observation of the world. By means of observing very closely what the human world is, what human beings are, then he [or she] can listen to the kind of sound, very deep sound – in other words, very minute vibration of the world and of the human beings. Very deep. That is called *suffering*.

Suffering is completely beyond your consciousness; it's there. Because constantly we are returning to the source, returning to the source, even though you don't know. So very naturally people are struggling for their life. Why do they struggle for their life? Because they want to get the something very deep, beyond consciousness or unconsciousness. That is they try to get that first moment of being present *right now, right here*. Where two worlds make one: intellect, spiritual world. This is this partition.

So, constantly there. Constantly we want to get it! But this is so-called reflection. Whatever we do, always we reflect upon ourselves. “Are you sure? Are you sure? Are you are happy? Yes, you are happy. But are you sure?” Constantly you ask yourself, and then try to get something which

makes it possible for your happiness to *be*. Still you want. Because this is to try to come back to the source, naturally. This is *suffering*, so-called.

So does suffering come from your intellect or your six senses? No. Completely beyond. That's why [it's a] "noble truth" – suffering is noble truth. So suffering is pretty deep.

So Avalokiteshvara listens to that sound. If you listen to the sound, immediately you are caught by the sound which you can hear, and also the sound known by human beings, [or] Avalokiteshvara. It's already subject and object. So we are already washed away by the sound-perceiving stream of mind – that means the six senses world, created by the six sense organs. We can hear, immediately we create six senses world. That is *samsara*. Then, naturally, most of us are completely washed away by this six senses world. Whatever you listen to or whatever you know – good or bad, wholesome, unwholesome, whatever – we always [are] carried away. We always are discriminating.

So very naturally Avalokiteshvara listens, but simultaneously Avalokiteshvara is free from knowing and [what] is known. Free from subject, object. It means Avalokiteshvara constantly stands up in the *source*, [the] first source, the very basis of the being, which is silent and stable, from where the life of all sentient beings blooms. So Avalokiteshvara constantly goes back to that space, that world, that point. And then, he or she can help. He or she can help all sentient beings.

So that is called "Avalokiteshvara turns the sound-perceiving stream of the mind, forsakes knowing and being known." According to Dōgen's message, I think you have to cut off the root of discriminating mind.

[You may ask,] "Shall I do zazen forever, in order to deepen my life, in order to make my life happy?" Yes, you should do it.

But you don't want to [have] the physical pain, and you don't want to get up early in the morning, et cetera. So, well... if you don't want, please, don't do zazen.

But still you want. If you want, please come. But you don't want. Always back and forth, back and forth. How can I help?

So all you have to do is, you have to forsake knowing and being known, "shall I" or "shall I not." You just be. At that time, you are a really great person, so-called Avalokiteshvara Bodhisattva, who can have a really

willing ear to listen to the sound of the world, the sound of you. And then, you can help. This is *compassion*.

So, this is the point of the practice in terms of Buddhist faith.

Constantly, first of all, you are a great container [of dharma]. Trust in this: you are a great container, beyond good or bad, right or wrong. Don't put yourself down, don't despise yourself. Anyway, encourage yourself constantly, and do it.

That's why Dōgen Zenji says practice is just like walking in the mist. It's a really good example: walking in the mist, constantly, and then, before you are conscious of it, your dress gets wet. This is our practice. Otherwise, you cannot continue to practice, no. It's very difficult to build up peaceful world. But if your practice is exactly just like walking in the mist: before you are conscious of it, your dress gets wet. If you practice like this, you really create peaceful life. And you can help all sentient beings.

– From “Principles of Practice, Talk 4: Faith” (March 22, 1986) at 55:14

In the next talk, Katagiri Roshi says even more to clarify the nature of *reflection* and *suffering*. In general we don't like suffering, but because of suffering, we can live, and we can practice:

Zazen is to “manage free practice and realization.”

Yesterday I [talked] about the practice. The practice is constantly you have to come back to the beginning, the very beginning of your existence. You come back to the very beginning of your birth, come back to the very beginning of standing, right now, right here. The very beginning. [It's] not to come back to the result which you can see. Standing, [for example,] is not a result. You have to come back to the *real* source of standing right now, right here. And then, this is real managing zazen.

What is this? When you come back to the real source, that is called “managing free practice and realization.” Because when you come back [to] that source, this is pretty hard, pretty hard practice. So it's practice! Because we are already creating our own life, and then we have to put it aside and go back to that *one*, that source. That's pretty hard practice. But

when you go back to there, it's not hard practice! Immediately you are supported.

Just like jumping into the ocean. Before you jump into the ocean, you have to think what the ocean is, what swimming is, what the fear is. I don't know what happens in my body and mind; maybe the moment when I jump into the ocean, I could die. I don't know; there is no guarantee. So, lots of stuff is coming up. That's pretty hard practice: training your body, your mind; understanding swimming, oceans, and the form of swimming, et cetera. But [...] the moment when you jump into the ocean, simultaneously your body floats. Very naturally, you are supported.

So, this is what is called "to learn the backward step which turns your light inwardly to illuminate yourself." *Fukanzazengi* says this. Or, plainly speaking, it is called *reflection*.

So, in a sense, *reflection* is considered as human suffering beyond human consciousness. [It's considered] in terms of hard practice. It's really hard practice, because suffering is really a serious matter in life. [...] Because you cannot get out from this.

But [because of] this suffering, you can survive! You have to appreciate this suffering, because we are seeking constantly for something more than the conscious world or unconscious world. We are seeking for it, *always*. This is the suffering. That suffering comes into existence beyond the functioning of your consciousness, so it is very serious in life. But if you realize that suffering – real suffering coming from the first moment of your being, exactly – then you can attain enlightenment. So, suffering makes you sad and painful, but on the other hand, suffering makes you become big laughter, relief. You can [be relieved], exactly.

Well, you can experience this in your life. If you cry day [after] day, one moment completely crying [turns into] big laughter. Just like the bottom of a bucket broken and the water rushing away from it, all of a sudden.

So, this is the real picture of human suffering.

– From "Principles of Practice, Talk 5: Direct Transmission" (March 23, 1986) at 28:28

Sometimes “take the backward step” or “turn the light around and shine it back” (*ekō henshō*) are understood as meaning to focus “internally” on ourselves, shutting out the “external” world. It is indeed sometimes described as “coming back to oneself,” but we have to be careful in how we understand this. A good example is found in one of Katagiri Roshi’s talks on *Blue Cliff Record* Case 52. He talks about “going out” and “coming back”:

So in our daily life, we are always getting something. To get something means to make a choice of direction, simultaneously, you can get [something]. But to get something means to throw [away] that [other] one. [That] means you negate the present.

To negate your present means “to go out.” Do you understand? To go out – so you never have a chance to come back to you, and settle down, settle yourself in the self, and be stable. You never do it. If you continually try to fill up the satisfaction, looking for a direction with the affective preferences, always there is uneasiness, and madness, lots of madness there. So that’s why it’s pretty hard for us to participate in ourselves *directly*.

But later in the same talk, Katagiri Roshi seems to slip into speaking about “internally” and “externally,” and quickly corrects himself:

Let’s participate in ourselves internally... [no,] not “internally”. If I say “internally,” simultaneously “externally” is there. *[He laughs.]* So, beyond internally or externally, participate *in you*, and learn *you* as you are, directly. Not imaginary, not turning toward, not with affective preference – constantly you do it.

Because your existence is *yours*. Just like the trees [in the mountains covered with snow]. But not yours! There is a huge vastness of existence, life force there, life energy there – behind you, or inside you. One tree, your tree, teaches you the name of the tree – your body, your name. But simultaneously the rhythm of the vastness of existence is there.

That is you. So you have to participate in that.

– From “*Blue Cliff Record* Case 52: Chao Chou Lets Asses Cross, Lets Horses Cross – Talk 1” (January 21, 1984) at 1:09:44

This may be why Katagiri Roshi clarifies that the backward step is “not [to] withdraw” and also “not escaping from.”

In Zen, an *eko* is the dedication we do after a ceremony or any activity. As Katagiri Roshi says, “*Eko* is turning the merit to all beings, instead of holding on to it by yourself.” Katagiri Roshi connects this *eko* (回向) with *ekō henshō* (回光返照), “turning the light and shining it inward.” In a talk on *karma*, he translates this line from *Fukanzazengi* as “to learn that one withdraws one step and turns the light inward on oneself.” But “withdraw one step” still does not mean “escape”:

... in Zen Buddhism particularly, Dōgen Zenji says it another [way, in *Fukanzazengi*]. He says, “To learn that one withdraws one step, and turns the light inward on oneself.” *To withdraw one step* doesn’t mean to escape from something. To withdraw means not to attach to what you have done, [but be] aware of what you have done. Whatever good or bad, don’t [attach to] it, don’t be crazy about it. It doesn’t mean you should ignore it, but you should awaken to what you have done. That is “to withdraw one step.” And then, if you do something good, withdraw one step and “turn the light” – [*the light*] means *merit* – “inward on oneself”: *inward* means wisdom, *on oneself* means oneself and another, all beings. Anyway, *share* life, or merit. Give life, or light, coming from what you have done, to everybody. That [is the meaning of] “to learn that one withdraws one step and turns the light inward on oneself.” At Eihei-ji Monastery, in the entrance of the study room, a handscroll there says [this]. This is the attitude toward studying the Buddha Way.

An obvious question here is how “inward” means “wisdom,” and how turning merit “on oneself” means “on all beings.” The answer is probably that this “oneself” is oneself in the sense of “your original face,” which is what manifests when we take the backward step.

Later in the same talk, he mentions this specifically in terms of karma:

So very naturally, you can see your life not only in terms of manifested karma, but also unmanifested karma, which manifested karma is backed by. So very naturally you can see your life extending to the beginningless past and endless future. This is called *eko*, or *virtuous quality*, or “learn

that one withdraws one step and turns the light inward on oneself.” Very naturally that means that you can learn humility, and modesty, compassion, toward oneself and another.

– From “Karma: Karmic Retribution in Present Life” (July 10, 1980) at 50:45

In other words, “turning the light around” is the same as turning the light to benefit all beings.

This connection is mentioned in the first talk in the *Fukanzazengi* (1979) series:

How can you experience enlightenment? Well, first: practice egolessness. How can you practice egolessness? *Samadhi*; one-pointedness. And then, just do it. And then if you just do it, there is no design on expecting any reward. Just do it. That is *shikantaza*.

That is really helpful. That is really a way of helping people: offering your merit, the merit of your practice, to all sentient beings.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 1” (June 9, 1979) at 56:36

Indeed, learning to “take the backward step that turns the light and shines it inward” is not self-centered – and although we are discussing *zazen* here, it is also not limited to *zazen*. We discussed that the backward step is *reflection*, which involves deep contemplation of *suffering*. Katagiri Roshi connects this practice to the Buddhist *pāramitās*, including the Precepts:

What we can do is, constantly cultivate this practice. Be in the realm of first thought, and practice there, and then simultaneously you can get the wisdom and its functioning, which is called *root of the wholesome*.

You never lose it, because wisdom and the functioning of wisdom is already planted in the bottom of your life. So, you never lose [it], whatever happens, all circumstances. That’s why, next moment, you can live in the Buddha land. How can we be free from karmic life? Well, just be there and practice. Very naturally, you are free. Exactly.

But our consciousness doesn't believe it. [*He laughs.*] Because consciousness is already involved in the very complicated world, so we don't believe it. But if you make your mind very clear and simple, going to the bottom of that reflection and discriminating world, then you can see how the first thought is working. And then, this is a really great light of instruction, how to live. All we have to do is to be there and practice, as best as we can. This is called *egolessness*.

So, very naturally, suffering begets selflessness. Okay? Suffering. Because suffering is fabricated [by] reflection and discriminating mind, and simultaneously it is constant unconscious effort, which allows you to go on and on, [to know] the bottom of the samsaric world. So, very naturally, you can see how to live, how to take care of the samsaric world.

So, let's go down to the bottom, and then be there, and try to live.

But still, in the samsaric world it is very difficult. That's why there are several skillful methods: so-called six *pāramitās*. Let's follow this way.

... So, *giving*. Constantly giving. This giving is not the usual giving; [it is] giving *pāramitā*. *Pāramitā* means "perfect accomplishment." So, giving must be accomplished perfectly. That means, completely open, and just do it.

And also *precepts*. Precepts are Buddha's suggestion how to live. Buddha's suggestions – not moral suggestions, not ethical suggestions, *Buddha's* suggestions. The suggestion of the truth, how to live.

And also *effort*, and *patience*. And also *wisdom* and *dhyana* (meditation).

Let's do this. And then, very naturally, we can come back to the source of *samsara*.

So that's why mindfulness is pretty important for us. Let's come back. *Mindfulness* [means] constantly remember. You must remember not only with a thought, but you must remember that first thought of *samsara* with the whole body and mind. That's why you can come back. And then, you can be in *dhyana*, so-called meditation, or *samādhi*. You can be there.

That is the practice of egolessness. So that's why Buddha says, "Suffering begets selflessness." Egolessness.

– From "Principles of Practice, Talk 3: High Resolve" (March 21, 1986) at 35:11

So we can see that zazen and the Precepts are closely related.

Far from withdrawing or escaping from life, “the backward step” is closely related to *prajñā*, or *wisdom*. Here Katagiri Roshi says that the *essence* of *prajñā* is “originally pure and clean” – we could say “perfect and all-pervading.” And the *function* of *prajñā* is “the backward step”:

I think *prajñā* can be considered in terms of three points.

One point is the *essence* of *prajñā*, the essence of wisdom. The essence of wisdom is [that] the self nature is originally pure and clean. This is the essence of *prajñāpāramitā*.

And the *function* of *prajñāpāramitā* is... how can I say it. In *Fukanzazengi*, Dōgen Zenji [says], “Learn the backward step that turns your light inwardly to illuminate yourself.” This is the *function* of the *prajñā*.

[...] The essence of *prajñā* is [that] the self nature is originally clean and pure, that’s why if wisdom works, [there is] nothing to bring in from outside. You have [it] already. So if you return to the original nature of existence, it simultaneously illuminates. If you come back, *you* illuminate. In other words, if you come back to *original nature of existence*, you can experience religious transformation at 360 degrees: exactly turn [around]. That is *illuminate*.

So no one helps you; you have to do it. If you practice sincerely, more or less everyone experiences this [...] 180 degree or 360 degree turn-[around].

Well, there are many kinds of experience. Some experience this very slowly, very slowly. And some experience a *little* shock. Some experience nothing, but it’s penetrating, soaking through just like rain soaking through the ceiling, something like that. So they don’t realize, but it’s soaking through.

Some experience a *big* shock, you know? Like thunder, lightning, exactly. Zen teaching is always talking about such experience, fascinating experience. But not everyone [experiences this], okay?

So, many kinds of experience. But more or less, people can turn over their lives 180 degrees, if you really come back to original nature. That

is how; this is [the] zazen we do. That is [the] “turn your light inwardly to illuminate yourself” that Dōgen Zenji mentions in [*Fukanzazengi*]. Is that clear?

– From “*Platform Sutra – Talk 2*” (March 20, 1987) at 3:26.

“Turning the light around to shine within” immediately leads to the next line: “Body and mind of themselves will drop away, and your original face will manifest.” Which brings us to the next chapter.